TIM RULES

The Complete Story

Chapters 1–75

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CHAPTER 1

The Worst Idea Ever

Monday

Okay, so today was supposed to be normal.

It wasn't.

It all started when I walked into school and saw a HUGE sign taped to the front doors.

STUDENT COUNCIL ELECTIONS — VOTE FOR YOUR LEADER!

I didn't really care about that stuff.

Until I saw who was running.

There was:

BRAD — the guy who thinks he's the strongest person alive.

JOSH — the guy who thinks he's the funniest person alive.

MASON — the guy who somehow gets free snacks from everyone.

And then there was...

ME.

Except I wasn't actually running.

Someone had written my name on the list.

I stared at it for about ten seconds.

"Who did this?" I asked.

My best friend, Noah, looked at the list.

Then he looked at me.

Then he started laughing.

"You should totally run."

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because I don't want to spend my free time doing school stuff."

Noah nodded.

"Fair."

Then he paused.

"But imagine if you won."

I thought about it.

Being the student council leader sounded pretty cool.

People would have to listen to me.

I could make rules.

I could change things.

I could—

"NO."

I looked over.

Brad was standing behind us.

"You're not becoming student council leader."

I raised an eyebrow.

"I wasn't planning to."

"Good."

Then Brad walked away like he had just won an argument.

Noah looked at me.

I looked at Noah.

He smiled.

I sighed.

"Fine."

"What?"

"I'm running."

And that's how I made the worst decision of my life.

LUNCH

By lunchtime, everyone somehow knew I was running.

I didn't even know how.

One kid came up to me and said,

"Tim! I'll vote for you if you make Fridays pizza day!"

Another said,

"Can you make homework illegal?"

Someone else asked,

"Can you make the teachers give us longer breaks?"

I started thinking this might actually be easy.

Then I realized something.

I didn't have a campaign.

Brad had posters.

Josh had buttons.

Mason was handing out sweets.

I had...

Nothing.

Noah looked at me.

"You need a slogan."

"A slogan?"

"Yeah."

I thought for a moment.

Then I said:

"TIM RULES."

Noah stared at me.

I stared at Noah.

"That's actually pretty good."

"Obviously."

By the end of lunch, we'd made three posters.

They weren't very good.

One of them said:

TIM RULES!

Another said:

VOTE TIM OR DON'T.

And the last one just said:

TIM

I thought the last one looked the most professional.

AFTER SCHOOL

When I got home, Mom asked me how school was.

"Fine."

"Anything interesting happen?"

I stopped.

I probably should have told her about the election.

But then I remembered something important.

Mom LOVES school stuff.

If I told her I was running for student council, she'd probably make me wear a shirt that said:

VOTE FOR TIM!

So I said:

"Nope."

I went upstairs.

I sat on my bed.

Then I looked at my campaign poster.

For some reason, I actually wanted to win.

Maybe being student council leader wouldn't be so bad.

Maybe I could actually change things.

Maybe people would finally—

BANG!

My bedroom door flew open.

Noah was standing there.

I jumped.

"HOW DID YOU GET IN HERE?!"

"Your mom let me in."

"What?"

He held up a piece of paper.

"The election is tomorrow."

I nearly fell off my bed.

"WHAT?!"

He smiled.

"Good luck, Mr. President."

Then he walked out.

I looked at my poster.

TIM RULES.

Yeah.

This was going to be a disaster.

CHAPTER 2

The Campaign War

Tuesday

Today was my first official campaign day.

Which sounds important.

It wasn't.

It started with me walking into school and seeing Brad standing in the hallway surrounded by about twenty people.

He had a giant banner behind him that said:

VOTE BRAD!

Underneath it was a picture of Brad flexing.

I don't know who took the picture, but they probably need glasses.

Noah walked up beside me.

"Uh-oh."

"What?"

"Look."

I looked at the other side of the hallway.

There was my poster.

Except someone had drawn a mustache on my face.

I immediately knew who did it.

"BRAD!"

Brad turned around.

He smiled.

"What?"

"You drew on my poster!"

He shrugged.

"Prove it."

I couldn't.

So I did what any reasonable person would do.

I walked over to his poster and drew a tiny mustache on his picture too.

Noah covered his face.

"Tim..."

"What?"

"You just started a war."

ROUND ONE

By break time, Brad had put up another poster.

It said:

BRAD WILL MAKE SCHOOL BETTER!

I put up one next to it.

TIM WILL MAKE SCHOOL LESS BORING!

Brad added:

BRAD IS STRONGER!

I added:

TIM IS SMARTER!

Brad:

BRAD IS COOLER!

Me:

TIM HAS BETTER HAIR!

Brad looked at my hair.

Then he looked at his.

"Okay, that's debatable."

I knew I had him.

ROUND TWO

At lunch, things got worse.

Brad announced that he was going to prove he was the best candidate by doing a push-up competition.

Nobody had asked him to do this.

But suddenly everyone was watching.

Brad dropped to the ground.

"ONE!"

"Two!"

"Three!"

He kept going.

I looked at Noah.

"Do I have to do this?"

"No."

"Good."

Brad reached thirty push-ups.

Then he looked at me.

"Your turn."

Everyone started chanting:

"TIM! TIM! TIM!"

This was a problem.

I had done approximately four push-ups in my entire life.

But I couldn't back down.

So I got on the ground.

"One."

My arms were already shaking.

"Two."

I started regretting everything.

"Three."

Then I collapsed.

Everyone went silent.

I slowly stood up.

"That was just a warm-up."

Noah started laughing so hard he nearly fell over.

Brad laughed too.

But then something unexpected happened.

A kid shouted:

"TIM STILL RULES!"

Everyone started cheering.

I smiled.

Maybe losing wasn't so bad.

ROUND THREE

After lunch, I discovered that Brad had started giving out free chocolate bars.

I looked at Noah.

"That's cheating."

"It's not technically cheating."

"It's bribery."

"Still not technically cheating."

I reached into my backpack.

I had one packet of chips.

I held it up.

"FREE CHIPS FOR EVERYONE!"

Suddenly, people surrounded me.

"TIM!"

"TIM, GIVE ME ONE!"

"TIM IS THE BEST!"

Brad stared at me.

"You can't beat me with chips."

I smiled.

"Watch me."

Within thirty seconds, the chips were gone.

I had completely forgotten that I actually wanted to eat them.

But at least my campaign was working.

Sort of.

THE FINAL BATTLE

After school, Brad walked up to me.

"Tomorrow."

"What?"

"We settle this."

"Settle what?"

"The election."

I sighed.

"Okay. How?"

Brad pointed toward the basketball court.

"One final challenge."

"What kind?"

He smiled.

"You'll find out."

That didn't sound good.

Noah walked over.

"What did he say?"

I looked at him.

"Apparently we're having a final challenge tomorrow."

Noah thought for a second.

Then he said:

"Should I start preparing your funeral?"

"Thanks."

"No problem."

I walked home wondering what Brad could possibly have planned.

And then I realized something.

Tomorrow was the school talent show.

Oh no.

Brad was going to make me compete in the talent show.

The only problem was...

I DON'T HAVE A TALENT.

CHAPTER 3

My Totally Amazing Talent

Wednesday

I woke up this morning with one thought in my head:

I HAVE NO TALENT.

I tried thinking of something I could do for the talent show.

I can play video games.

But apparently sitting on a couch and pressing buttons isn't considered a talent.

I can eat a lot of chips.

But Mom said that's "not something to be proud of."

I can sleep for twelve hours straight.

That one was actually impressive, but I didn't think the teachers would let me perform it.

Then I remembered something.

Something I had been practicing for years without even realizing it.

I can make extremely weird noises with my mouth.

Not normal noises.

I can make a noise that sounds like a duck choking.

I can make a noise that sounds like a car starting.

And I can make this weird squeaking sound that I discovered when I was six.

I don't know why I know how to do these things.

But I do.

I immediately called Noah.

"I've got my talent!"

"What is it?"

"I can make weird noises."

There was a long silence.

Then Noah said:

"Please don't."

"Why?"

"Because I have to sit in the audience."

"That's the point."

AT SCHOOL

When I arrived at school, Brad was already waiting for me.

"So," he said, "what's your talent?"

I wasn't going to tell him.

Then I made the mistake of bragging.

"Something amazing."

Brad laughed.

"I'll believe it when I see it."

Noah walked past us.

"Trust me, Brad. You don't want to see it."

Brad looked confused.

I smiled.

"Exactly."

THE TALENT SHOW

After lunch, everyone gathered in the hall.

There were about fifty students sitting in the audience.

The teacher walked onto the stage.

"Welcome to the annual school talent show!"

Everyone clapped.

First, a girl played the piano.

Then someone did magic tricks.

Then Brad went on stage.

Of course.

His talent was apparently doing basketball tricks.

He bounced the ball behind his back.

Then between his legs.

Then he threw it in the air and caught it.

Everyone cheered.

Brad looked at me from the stage.

He gave me a thumbs-up.

I wanted to disappear.

Then the teacher said:

"Next up... Tim!"

My stomach dropped.

I slowly walked onto the stage.

The entire hall was staring at me.

I looked at Noah.

He was already laughing.

I took a deep breath.

"Okay."

I walked up to the microphone.

"My talent is..."

I stopped.

"...making weird noises."

Nobody said anything.

Then someone in the back shouted:

"WHAT?"

I closed my eyes.

This was a terrible idea.

But I had already started.

I took a deep breath.

And made the duck noise.

"QUAAAAAAK-HRRRRRKK!"

The entire hall went silent.

Then—

Someone laughed.

Then another person laughed.

Then the whole room exploded.

I started laughing too.

So I did the car noise.

"BRRRRRRMMMMM-BRRRMMMM!"

Then the squeak.

"EEEEEEEEEEK!"

People were practically falling out of their chairs.

Even the teacher was laughing.

I finished with my best noise.

The sound of a dying printer.

"BEEP... BEEP... KRRRRR... EEEEE... BZZZZZZ!"

The audience went crazy.

I stood there completely confused.

I had expected everyone to make fun of me.

Instead, people were cheering.

I looked over at Brad.

He wasn't laughing.

He looked worried.

Very worried.

AFTER THE SHOW

When I got off the stage, Noah ran over.

"TIM!"

"What?"

"That was actually amazing!"

"I know."

"You looked like an idiot."

"I know."

"But everyone loved it."

I smiled.

Maybe having a weird talent wasn't so bad.

Then Brad walked over.

"Congratulations."

I stared at him.

"Thanks?"

He looked serious.

"But you haven't won yet."

"What do you mean?"

He pointed at the stage.

"The judges are announcing the winner tomorrow."

I suddenly remembered the election.

The talent show was supposed to be our final challenge.

If I won...

I might actually beat Brad.

Brad walked away.

Noah looked at me.

"You realize what's happening, right?"

"What?"

"You might actually become student council leader."

I smiled.

Then I heard a loud voice behind me.

"TIM!"

I turned around.

It was the principal.

He looked angry.

"Can I speak to you for a moment?"

My smile disappeared.

Uh-oh.

I was pretty sure principals don't usually ask to talk to you after you make a dying-printer noise in front of the entire school.

CHAPTER 4

The Principal's Office

Wednesday

Okay.

When the principal tells you to come to his office, there are only two possibilities.

Either you are in REALLY big trouble...

Or you are about to get blamed for something you didn't do.

I was hoping for the second one.

I followed him down the hallway.

Noah tried to come with me.

The principal stopped him.

"Just Tim."

Noah gave me a thumbs-up.

Then he whispered:

"If you don't come back, I'll tell everyone you were eaten by the principal."

"Thanks."

THE OFFICE

I sat in the chair across from the principal.

He looked at me.

I looked at him.

He looked at me again.

I started getting nervous.

Finally, he said:

"Tim, I wanted to talk to you about your performance."

Oh no.

I knew it.

I was in trouble.

"I'm sorry about the dying printer noise."

He looked confused.

"The what?"

"The noise I made."

He started laughing.

"No, Tim. That's actually why I called you in."

I waited.

"You made the entire school laugh."

I nodded.

"Is that bad?"

"No. Quite the opposite."

He opened a drawer and pulled out a piece of paper.

"Your performance has been entered into the school talent competition."

"But I was already in the talent show."

"Yes. But you have been selected for the final."

I stared at him.

"The final?"

He nodded.

"You'll perform tomorrow in front of the judges."

I suddenly felt sick.

Tomorrow.

The same day the election results would be announced.

And Brad was going to be there.

This was getting serious.

THE HALLWAY

When I came out of the office, Noah was waiting.

"So?"

"I'm in the final."

His eyes went wide.

"Seriously?"

"Yep."

He grabbed my shoulders.

"TIM! YOU COULD WIN!"

"I know."

"Then you need a better performance."

I thought about it.

"I could make more noises."

"No."

"Better noises?"

"No."

"I could learn an instrument."

"You have one day."

"Then no."

We stood there thinking.

Suddenly Noah snapped his fingers.

"I've got it!"

"What?"

"We make your performance HUGE."

"How?"

He smiled.

"Trust me."

I immediately knew that was a bad sign.

AFTER SCHOOL

We went to my house to practice.

Noah brought a speaker.

I brought a packet of chips.

He said the chips weren't part of the performance.

I disagreed.

We spent two hours planning.

By the end, we had created what Noah called:

THE TIM NOISE SHOW.

It included:

The duck noise

The car noise

The dying printer

A vacuum cleaner

A police siren

A dinosaur

And something Noah called "the noise of pure suffering"

I didn't even know I could make half of those noises.

Then Noah had an idea.

"At the end, you should do something nobody expects."

"Like what?"

He pointed at my guitar.

I stared at it.

"No."

"Why?"

"I don't know how to play."

"Exactly."

THURSDAY

The next morning, I walked into school.

Everyone was talking about the talent show.

Then I saw Brad.

He walked up to me.

"Ready to lose?"

I smiled.

"Actually..."

I pointed toward the stage.

"I'm ready to win."

Brad laughed.

"You?"

"Yep."

He shook his head.

"You don't stand a chance."

Then he walked away.

Noah came running over.

"Tim!"

"What?"

"There's a problem."

"What?"

He pointed toward the stage.

Brad had brought something with him.

A giant speaker.

And a microphone.

And behind him was a banner.

BRAD'S FINAL PERFORMANCE!

Noah looked at me.

"He's prepared."

I looked at our tiny speaker.

Then at Brad's giant speaker.

Then at my guitar.

This was going to be a disaster.

But there was no turning back now.

Tomorrow, Tim Rules.

CHAPTER 5

The Final Showdown

Thursday

Today was the day.

The talent show final.

The election results.

And, apparently, the day I was going to embarrass myself in front of the entire school.

Again.

I woke up at 6:30 in the morning and immediately remembered what was happening.

I pulled my blanket over my head.

Maybe if I stayed in bed all day, the election would just happen without me.

Then Mom opened my door.

"Tim! You're going to be late!"

I groaned.

"I don't want to go."

"Why?"

"Because I'm probably going to make weird noises in front of everyone."

Mom paused.

"You mean the talent show?"

"Yes."

She smiled.

"I think you'll do great."

That's the problem with parents.

They always think you're going to do great.

Even when you have absolutely no idea what you're doing.

THE WALK TO SCHOOL

I met Noah halfway to school.

He was carrying my speaker.

I was carrying my guitar.

Neither of us knew how to use either of them properly.

Noah looked at me.

"Ready?"

"No."

"Good."

We kept walking.

After about a minute, I said:

"What if I lose?"

"You probably will."

"Thanks."

"But you'll still be famous."

"How?"

"Everyone will remember the guy who made a dying-printer noise on stage."

I thought about it.

"That's actually worse."

SCHOOL

When we arrived, the entire school was already decorated for the final.

There were balloons everywhere.

There were posters hanging from the walls.

And right in the middle of the hallway was Brad's giant campaign banner.

VOTE BRAD!

Underneath it was a picture of him giving two thumbs up.

I looked at Noah.

"Why does he have so much money?"

"No idea."

We walked past the banner.

Then I noticed something.

Someone had put a tiny sticker underneath Brad's face.

It said:

TIM RULES

I looked at Noah.

He smiled.

"Not me."

"Sure."

THE FINAL BEGINS

At lunchtime, everyone gathered in the hall.

The principal walked onto the stage.

"Welcome to the final round of this year's talent competition!"

Everyone cheered.

I was sitting backstage with Noah.

My hands were shaking.

"What if I forget all my noises?"

"You won't."

"What if I make the wrong noise?"

"There are no wrong noises."

"What if I accidentally make the sound of a goat?"

Noah shrugged.

"Then you make the sound of a goat."

I nodded.

That was strangely comforting.

Then the principal announced:

"Our first finalist is..."

"BRAD!"

The crowd went crazy.

Brad walked onto the stage wearing sunglasses.

Inside.

For some reason.

He started with basketball tricks.

He spun the ball on his finger.

Then he threw it behind his back.

Then he kicked it into the air and caught it.

Everyone cheered.

Then the music started.

Brad started dancing.

I looked at Noah.

"Is this a talent show or a concert?"

"I don't know."

Brad finished by doing a backflip.

The crowd went completely insane.

He walked off the stage and looked directly at me.

He smiled.

I knew what that smile meant.

Your turn.

MY TURN

The principal came backstage.

"Tim, you're next."

My stomach dropped.

I stood up.

Noah gave me a high five.

"Remember the plan."

I nodded.

I walked onto the stage.

Hundreds of eyes were staring at me.

The lights were so bright that I could barely see anyone.

I walked up to the microphone.

There was a long silence.

Then someone shouted:

"MAKE THE DUCK!"

Everyone laughed.

I smiled.

"Okay."

I took a deep breath.

Then I made the duck noise.

"QUAAAAAAK-HRRRRRKK!"

The audience exploded.

I made the car noise.

"BRRRRMMMM-BRRRRMMMM!"

More cheering.

Then the police siren.

"WEE-OOO! WEE-OOO!"

Someone in the audience shouted:

"TIM RULES!"

Everyone started chanting it.

"TIM! TIM! TIM! TIM!"

I couldn't believe it.

I was actually winning.

Then I remembered the final part.

The guitar.

I walked over to it.

The audience went quiet.

I picked it up.

I held it like I knew what I was doing.

Then I strummed one random chord.

TWANG.

It sounded terrible.

Everyone laughed.

I laughed too.

"Okay," I said into the microphone.

"That was intentional."

It wasn't.

I strummed another chord.

TWANG.

Then another.

TWANG.

Noah was backstage covering his face.

I decided to stop before I completely destroyed the guitar.

I put it down.

Then I did my final noise.

The noise of pure suffering.

"AAAAAAAGHHHHH-BRRRRR-EEEEEEEEE!"

The hall went crazy.

People were standing up.

Even some teachers were laughing.

I bowed.

Then I ran off the stage.

BACKSTAGE

Noah grabbed me.

"THAT WAS AMAZING!"

"I nearly died."

"But everyone loved it!"

I looked through the curtain.

The entire audience was still cheering.

Then I saw Brad.

He wasn't cheering.

He was staring at me.

I walked over.

He crossed his arms.

"Pretty good."

"Thanks."

"But I still won."

I raised an eyebrow.

"What makes you think that?"

He pointed at the judges.

"They're going to pick the best talent."

I smiled.

"Maybe."

Then the principal walked onto the stage.

"Thank you to all of our finalists!"

The audience clapped.

"Now, before we announce the talent show winner..."

He paused.

"...we have one more announcement."

I suddenly remembered.

THE ELECTION.

THE RESULTS

The principal picked up an envelope.

"This year's student council election was extremely close."

I looked at Brad.

Brad looked at me.

Noah whispered:

"Here we go."

The principal opened the envelope.

"The winner is..."

He paused.

Way too long.

I was sweating.

"The winner is..."

Everyone leaned forward.

"TIM!"

For a second, I didn't understand what had happened.

Then the entire hall exploded.

"TIM! TIM! TIM! TIM!"

Noah jumped up.

"I KNEW IT!"

I stood there completely frozen.

Me.

I had actually won.

Brad looked shocked.

Then he walked over.

I thought he was going to be angry.

Instead, he held out his hand.

"Good job."

I shook it.

"Thanks."

He smiled.

"But next year..."

I already knew what he was going to say.

"...I'm winning."

I laughed.

"Good luck."

The principal handed me a little badge that said:

STUDENT COUNCIL LEADER

I put it on.

Noah walked over.

"So, Mr. President..."

"Yeah?"

"What are you going to do first?"

I thought about it.

There were a million things I could change.

Better lunches.

Longer breaks.

Less homework.

Maybe even pizza Fridays.

I smiled.

"I've got an idea."

Noah looked worried.

"What kind of idea?"

I pointed toward the cafeteria.

"We're getting pizza."

Noah grinned.

Now THAT was leadership.

And that's how I became student council leader.

Of course, I didn't know it yet...

But winning the election was going to be the easy part.

CHAPTER 6

The First Rule

Friday

Being student council leader sounded amazing.

Until I actually became student council leader.

At 8:00 this morning, I was sitting in the student council room with a piece of paper in front of me.

At the top it said:

FIRST MEETING — IMPORTANT

Underneath that were three questions.

1. What should we change?

2. What should we improve?

3. What should we do about the school festival?

I stared at the third question.

"The school festival?"

The teacher sitting across from me nodded.

"Yes. It's in three weeks."

I looked at Noah.

He looked at me.

"Three weeks?" I asked.

"Three weeks," the teacher repeated.

"And I'm responsible for it?"

"You're the student council leader."

I suddenly missed being a normal student.

Brad was sitting at the other side of the table.

He leaned back in his chair.

"Don't worry, Tim. I'll help."

I looked at him suspiciously.

"Why?"

He smiled.

"Because I want the festival to actually be good."

That sounded reasonable.

Which made it even more suspicious.

The meeting started.

Everyone began suggesting ideas.

"A food stall!"

"A dunk tank!"

"A football tournament!"

"A gaming competition!"

I raised my hand.

"What about a giant water slide?"

The teacher looked at me.

"Where would we get a giant water slide?"

I lowered my hand.

"Good question."

Brad raised his hand.

"How about a sports tournament?"

Everyone liked the idea.

I didn't.

"That's basically just sports day."

Brad shrugged.

"Sports day is fun."

"Not for people who aren't good at sports."

Everyone looked at me.

I slowly sat down.

"Moving on."

After an hour, we had a huge list of ideas.

There was only one problem.

We had almost no money.

The teacher explained that the student council had a limited budget.

I looked at our list.

Then I looked at Brad.

Brad looked at me.

"Fundraiser," we both said at the same time.

And that's when everything went wrong.

THE GREAT FUNDRAISER

We decided to have a competition.

Every class would raise money.

The class that raised the most would get a prize.

It sounded simple.

It wasn't.

Because Brad immediately turned it into a competition between us.

"Tim versus Brad."

I pointed at myself.

"Why am I involved?"

"You're the leader."

"So?"

"So if my team wins, everyone will know I'm better."

I stared at him.

"You're making this personal."

"Yep."

Noah whispered:

"He's very committed."

I sighed.

"Fine."

And that was how the biggest fundraising competition in school history began.

I just didn't know yet that Brad was willing to do almost anything to win.

CHAPTER 7

Operation: Make Money

Monday

Our fundraiser officially started today.

My team had a meeting before school.

There were five of us:

Me.

Noah.

Mia.

Ethan.

And a kid named Kyle who joined because he thought there would be free food.

There wasn't.

Our goal was to raise enough money for the school festival.

I stood in front of everyone.

"Okay. We need ideas."

Mia raised her hand.

"Car wash."

"Good."

Ethan said:

"Sponsored run."

"Good."

Noah said:

"Sell baked goods."

"Good."

Kyle raised his hand.

"Sell my brother."

Everyone stared at him.

"What?"

"My mom says he's annoying."

"No."

Kyle lowered his hand.

"Fine."

We split up the jobs.

Noah would organize the baked goods.

Mia would handle the car wash.

Ethan would organize the sponsored run.

And I would—

"Tim?"

I looked up.

"Yes?"

"You need to do something too."

"Right."

I thought.

"How about I make posters?"

Noah shook his head.

"You have to do something that actually makes money."

I sighed.

"Fine."

At break, I walked around the school trying to think of an idea.

Then I saw Brad.

He was standing beside a table covered in cupcakes.

A huge sign said:

BRAD'S SUPER CUPCAKE CHALLENGE

I walked over.

"What is this?"

Brad smiled.

"People pay to throw a cupcake at me."

I stared at him.

"You charge them?"

"One rand per throw."

I looked at the line.

There were at least thirty people waiting.

"You've made money from this?"

"Obviously."

I couldn't believe it.

Then Brad handed me a cupcake.

"Want to throw one?"

I looked at him.

"How much?"

"One rand."

I paid him.

Then I threw the cupcake.

SPLAT.

It hit him directly in the face.

Everyone laughed.

Brad wiped frosting off his nose.

"Nice shot."

I smiled.

"Thanks."

Then I realized something.

If Brad could make money by getting hit in the face with cupcakes...

I could probably do something even better.

MY BIG IDEA

At lunch, I announced my plan.

Noah looked worried.

"What are you going to do?"

I smiled.

"I am going to let people pay me to embarrass myself."

Noah stared at me.

"You're going to have to be more specific."

I held up a sign.

It said:

TIM'S EMBARRASSMENT CHALLENGE

People could pay to make me do embarrassing challenges.

Sing.

Dance.

Tell terrible jokes.

Wear ridiculous clothes.

Do impressions.

Basically anything that wasn't dangerous.

Within ten minutes, I had a crowd.

The first person paid me five rand.

"Do the chicken dance."

I sighed.

Then I started dancing.

BUK BUK BUK BUK!

Everyone laughed.

Someone gave me ten rand to sing the school anthem like an opera singer.

Someone else paid me to walk backward around the playground.

Then someone paid me twenty rand to wear a giant pair of sunglasses.

By the end of lunch, I'd made more money than Brad.

I looked at the total.

R147.

Noah's mouth dropped open.

"Tim."

"Yeah?"

"This might actually work."

I smiled.

"Of course it will."

Then Brad appeared.

He looked at the money.

Then at me.

Then at the sign.

"Nice."

"Thanks."

"But tomorrow..."

He smiled.

"...I'm raising the stakes."

CHAPTER 8

Brad Strikes Back

Tuesday

I should have known Brad was planning something.

Because when I arrived at school, there was a massive crowd around the entrance.

And in the middle of it was Brad.

He was wearing a ridiculous superhero costume.

A cape.

A mask.

Everything.

Behind him was a giant sign:

BRAD'S EXTREME CHALLENGE

I walked closer.

"What are you doing?"

Brad pointed at the sign.

"People pay to challenge me."

"That's my idea!"

He shook his head.

"It's better now."

A student walked up.

"I'll give you ten rand if you can do fifty push-ups."

Brad dropped to the ground.

"Easy."

He did fifty.

Everyone cheered.

Then someone challenged him to run around the school carrying a backpack full of books.

He did it.

Then another person challenged him to eat three extremely sour sweets.

He did that too.

Brad was making money incredibly quickly.

I looked at Noah.

"We need a new plan."

Noah nodded.

"Definitely."

THE CHALLENGE

At lunch, Brad came over.

"I've got an idea."

"I don't like that sentence."

"We combine our challenges."

"What?"

"One final challenge."

He pointed toward the sports field.

"We both do the same challenge."

"And?"

"Whoever raises the most money wins."

I thought about it.

That actually sounded fair.

"What challenge?"

Brad smiled.

"You'll find out."

I immediately regretted agreeing.

After school, everyone gathered on the field.

The teacher explained the challenge.

We had to complete ten ridiculous tasks.

The person who completed all ten first would win.

The tasks included:

Running around the field.

Balancing a book on our heads.

Doing ten jumping jacks.

Putting on three school uniforms.

Solving a puzzle.

Carrying a bucket of water.

And finally...

Eating a lemon.

I stared at the lemon.

"Who came up with this?"

The teacher pointed at Brad.

"Brad."

"Of course."

The whistle blew.

We started running.

Brad was much faster than me.

He reached the book-balancing station first.

I tried to catch up.

Then the book fell off my head.

I picked it up.

Then it fell again.

Everyone laughed.

Brad was already halfway through the jumping jacks.

I finally got through the first few tasks.

Then came the bucket.

I picked it up.

It was heavier than I expected.

I took three steps.

Then—

SPLASH!

Water went everywhere.

Including all over me.

Everyone started laughing.

Brad was laughing so hard he nearly dropped his bucket too.

I laughed.

"Okay! That was funny."

By the final challenge, Brad was ahead.

He grabbed the lemon.

He bit into it.

His face immediately changed.

He looked like he'd just discovered that lemons were actually poisonous.

I grabbed mine.

I bit into it.

My entire face twisted.

We both started laughing.

Somehow, we finished at almost exactly the same time.

The teacher checked the money.

Brad had raised slightly more.

He won.

But only by twelve rand.

He held out his hand.

"Good game."

I shook it.

"Next time."

Brad smiled.

"Definitely."

For once, it didn't feel like we were enemies.

We were rivals.

And somehow...

That was more fun.

CHAPTER 9

The Festival Problem

Wednesday

I thought things were finally going well.

Then the principal called a meeting.

That is never good.

I sat in his office with Noah and Brad.

The principal placed a folder on the desk.

"We have a problem."

I looked at Brad.

Brad looked at me.

"What kind of problem?" I asked.

"The school festival."

I sighed.

"What about it?"

"We don't have enough money."

I stared at him.

"But we've been fundraising."

"Yes."

"How much do we need?"

He told us the amount.

I nearly fell out of my chair.

"WHAT?!"

Noah looked shocked.

Brad looked serious.

The amount was almost double what we had raised.

"So we're cancelling the festival?" I asked.

The principal shook his head.

"Not yet."

He explained that we had one week to raise the rest.

One week.

And if we failed...

There would be no festival.

I looked at Noah.

Then Brad.

Brad stood up.

"We'll do it."

The principal smiled.

"That's what I wanted to hear."

THE PLAN

We gathered everyone after school.

I stood in front of the student council.

"We have one week."

Everyone started talking.

"We need a massive fundraiser."

"What about a concert?"

"A raffle?"

"A sports tournament?"

Then Noah raised his hand.

"What if we do all of them?"

Everyone went quiet.

I looked at him.

"Explain."

"We have seven days."

He started counting.

"Monday: bake sale."

"Tuesday: sports tournament."

"Wednesday: talent show."

"Thursday: car wash."

"Friday: big concert."

"Saturday: festival."

I stared at him.

"That's insane."

He smiled.

"Exactly."

Brad stood up.

"I'll organize the sports tournament."

I nodded.

"Mia can organize the car wash."

"Ethan can handle the concert."

"And I'll handle the talent show."

Everyone agreed.

For the first time, Brad and I were actually working together.

Maybe this wouldn't be so bad.

THE PROBLEM

As we were leaving, I noticed something.

A poster had been put up on the school noticeboard.

It wasn't ours.

It wasn't Brad's.

It was from another school.

It said:

THE ANNUAL INTERSCHOOL CHALLENGE

And underneath:

OUR SCHOOL VS RIVERDALE HIGH

The winner would receive a huge cash prize.

I looked at Noah.

He looked at me.

Brad walked over.

"How much?"

I pointed at the poster.

He read it.

His eyes widened.

"That's enough to pay for the whole festival."

I smiled.

"Then we're entering."

Brad nodded.

But there was one problem.

The competition was tomorrow.

And we had absolutely no idea what the challenge was.

CHAPTER 10

The Inter-School Challenge

Thursday

I woke up with a terrible feeling.

Today was the inter-school challenge.

I didn't know what we were competing in.

I didn't know who we were competing against.

And I definitely didn't know why Brad had packed three pairs of shoes.

When I arrived at school, buses were waiting outside.

Students were everywhere.

The principal walked over.

"Everyone ready?"

"No," I said.

He smiled.

"Good."

We got onto the bus.

Twenty minutes later, we arrived at Riverdale High.

It was huge.

Their school looked like it had been built specifically to make our school look bad.

There were giant sports fields.

A massive hall.

And even a swimming pool.

Brad looked out the window.

"We're winning."

I looked at him.

"You don't even know the challenge."

"Doesn't matter."

We got off the bus.

A teacher from Riverdale welcomed us.

"Today's competition has five rounds."

I immediately regretted coming.

The first round was trivia.

I was good at trivia.

Finally!

Something I could actually do.

The questions started.

"What is the capital of Australia?"

I pressed the button.

"Canberra!"

Correct.

"What planet is known as the Red Planet?"

"Mars!"

Correct.

Brad stared at me.

"Okay, Tim."

I smiled.

"Maybe I'm useful."

ROUND TWO

Physical challenge.

I looked at Brad.

"Your turn."

Brad grinned.

The challenge was an obstacle course.

He destroyed it.

He climbed.

He jumped.

He crawled.

He even did a backflip over a barrier.

Our school won the round.

ROUND THREE

Team puzzle.

This one was harder.

We had to put together a giant puzzle.

Everyone started arguing.

"That piece goes there!"

"No, it doesn't!"

"Yes, it does!"

Brad picked up a piece.

"Where does this go?"

I looked at it.

"Right there."

He placed it.

It fit perfectly.

Brad looked at me.

"How did you know?"

I shrugged.

"Pure genius."

ROUND FOUR

Talent.

I immediately knew we were in trouble.

Riverdale had a magician.

Then a drummer.

Then someone who could juggle six objects at once.

Our school sent a girl who could sing beautifully.

Then another student did karate.

Then Brad went up.

He did his basketball tricks.

Everyone cheered.

Then it was my turn.

I walked onto the stage.

The audience waited.

I took a deep breath.

And made the duck noise.

"QUAAAAAAK-HRRRRK!"

Silence.

Then the Riverdale students started laughing.

Not at me.

With me.

I followed with the car.

Then the police siren.

Then the dying printer.

By the end, even the judges were laughing.

We won the round.

I walked offstage.

Brad gave me a high five.

"Nice."

"Thanks."

THE FINAL ROUND

We were tied.

The final challenge would decide everything.

The teacher walked onto the field.

"The final round is..."

He paused.

"...the giant relay."

I looked at the track.

There were five stations.

Running.

Throwing.

Jumping.

Balancing.

And finally...

A mystery station.

Each school chose five students.

Brad immediately volunteered.

Noah volunteered.

Mia volunteered.

Ethan volunteered.

And, unfortunately, me.

The race started.

Brad took the first section.

He was incredible.

Noah took the second.

Mia took the third.

Ethan took the fourth.

Then the baton came to me.

I ran toward the final station.

There was a giant box.

I opened it.

Inside was...

A rubber chicken.

I stared at it.

"What am I supposed to do with this?!"

The teacher shouted:

"BRING IT TO THE FINISH LINE!"

I grabbed the chicken.

I ran.

Riverdale was right behind me.

I sprinted toward the finish.

Five metres.

Three metres.

One metre.

I threw myself across the line.

BEEP!

The crowd screamed.

We had won.

Our entire team jumped on me.

Brad grabbed the rubber chicken.

He held it above his head.

"We did it!"

Everyone cheered.

The principal handed us the prize money.

It was enough.

More than enough.

The festival was saved.

As we climbed back onto the bus, I sat beside Noah.

He looked at me.

"Pretty crazy week."

I nodded.

"Yeah."

Then I looked at the rubber chicken sitting on the seat across from us.

"Why did they have a rubber chicken?"

Noah shrugged.

"I don't know."

The chicken suddenly made a noise.

SQUEEEEEAK.

We both stared at it.

I slowly smiled.

"I have an idea."

Noah immediately shook his head.

"No."

"What?"

"Whatever you're thinking..."

He pointed at me.

"...don't."

I smiled wider.

Too late.

I was already thinking of a new campaign idea.

And it involved a rubber chicken.

CHAPTER 11

The Rubber Chicken

Friday

I had a brilliant idea.

At least, I thought it was brilliant.

Noah disagreed.

"This is stupid."

I held up the rubber chicken.

"You haven't even heard the idea."

"I don't need to."

"That's rude."

We were sitting in the student council room, trying to figure out how to raise more money for the festival.

We had enough money to keep the festival going, but we still wanted to make it bigger.

I put the chicken on the table.

"We auction this."

Noah stared at it.

"Who would buy a rubber chicken?"

"Someone."

"Who?"

"I don't know."

"How much?"

"Maybe... fifty rand?"

Noah laughed.

"Tim, that thing is worth about ten rand."

I picked up the chicken.

"Then we make it famous."

OPERATION CHICKEN

We made a poster.

THE LEGENDARY RUBBER CHICKEN

OWN THE CHICKEN THAT WON THE INTER-SCHOOL CHALLENGE!

We put it up around school.

At first, nobody cared.

Then someone asked:

"Did that actually win the competition?"

I nodded.

"It crossed the finish line before Riverdale."

Technically, I had carried it.

But details weren't important.

By lunchtime, people were talking about it.

Someone offered ten rand.

Someone else offered twenty.

Then Brad walked over.

"I'll give you fifty."

I stared at him.

"For the chicken?"

"Yep."

Noah whispered:

"Take it."

I shook my head.

"No."

Brad raised an eyebrow.

"Why?"

"Because I have a better idea."

I held up the chicken.

"We're going to keep it as the official mascot of the festival."

Everyone nearby started cheering.

Brad laughed.

"You've officially lost your mind."

"Maybe."

That afternoon, we gave the chicken a name.

There were lots of suggestions.

Chicken Bob.

Sir Clucks.

Cluck Norris.

But eventually, Noah suggested:

Greg.

Nobody knew why.

So obviously, we chose Greg.

From that day forward, Greg became the official mascot of the school festival.

I thought it was hilarious.

The principal didn't.

CHAPTER 12

Greg's First Day

Monday

Greg was becoming famous.

This was a sentence I never thought I'd write.

Someone had made him a tiny hat.

Someone else made him a cape.

By lunchtime, he had his own fan club.

I walked into the cafeteria and saw about fifteen kids surrounding him.

"What are you doing?"

One kid said:

"We're protecting Greg."

"From what?"

"Brad."

I looked across the cafeteria.

Brad was sitting at a table, staring at us.

He slowly stood up.

He walked over.

"Give me the chicken."

"No."

"Why?"

"I don't trust you."

Brad rolled his eyes.

"I'm not going to steal it."

He reached for Greg.

I moved him away.

Brad sighed.

"Fine."

Then he pulled something out of his backpack.

A second rubber chicken.

I stared at it.

"No."

Brad grinned.

"Yes."

His chicken was bigger.

Much bigger.

It was almost twice the size of Greg.

The cafeteria went silent.

Someone whispered:

"There's another one."

Brad held it up.

"This is Frank."

Noah looked at me.

"We've got a problem."

I nodded.

"Definitely."

THE CHICKEN WAR

By the end of the day, everyone had picked a side.

Team Greg.

Or Team Frank.

People made posters.

People made badges.

Someone even started selling chicken-shaped cookies.

The teachers tried to stop it.

They failed.

Brad walked past me after school.

"Your chicken is going down."

I held up Greg.

"Bring it."

The rivalry was back.

Except this time...

It was about rubber chickens.

CHAPTER 13

The Chicken Tournament

Tuesday

I arrived at school and immediately saw a giant poster.

THE GREAT CHICKEN TOURNAMENT

I stared at it.

"Brad."

He appeared behind me.

"Yes?"

"What is this?"

"Our final showdown."

"We've already had like five final showdowns."

"This one is different."

"How?"

He pointed at the poster.

"Three events."

I read them.

1. Chicken Relay

2. Chicken Basketball

3. Chicken Wrestling

I looked at him.

"Chicken wrestling?"

"Obviously."

"No."

Brad smiled.

"Scared?"

I sighed.

"Fine."

CHICKEN RELAY

The first challenge was simple.

Carry your chicken around the field and back.

Brad went first.

He sprinted.

I followed.

Halfway around the field, Greg slipped out of my hands.

I stopped.

Brad kept running.

I picked Greg up.

"Sorry!"

I ran after him.

Brad crossed the finish line first.

1–0.

CHICKEN BASKETBALL

This one was ridiculous.

We had to throw our chickens into a basketball hoop.

Brad's chicken was huge.

That should have made it easier.

It wasn't.

He threw Frank.

Frank bounced off the rim.

Then hit Brad in the head.

Everyone laughed.

I threw Greg.

He went straight through the hoop.

SCORE!

The crowd went crazy.

1–1.

CHICKEN WRESTLING

I thought this was going to be the stupidest part.

I was wrong.

The rule was that we had to push the other person's chicken out of a circle.

Brad pushed Frank forward.

I pushed Greg.

They bumped into each other.

Nothing happened.

Brad pushed harder.

I pushed harder.

Then Greg suddenly slipped.

He flew out of my hands.

Straight into Brad.

Brad fell backward.

The crowd exploded.

I stared at Greg.

Then at Brad.

Then at Greg again.

"Did my chicken just tackle you?"

Brad laughed.

"Apparently."

I helped him up.

"Guess that means I win."

Brad nodded.

"Today."

As everyone left, Brad stopped me.

"You know..."

"What?"

"This is actually fun."

I smiled.

"Yeah."

He looked at Greg.

"Don't tell anyone I said that."

"Deal."

CHAPTER 14

The New Student

Wednesday

We got a new student today.

Her name was Sophie.

She walked into class halfway through the morning.

The teacher introduced her.

"Everyone, this is Sophie. She just moved here."

Sophie smiled.

"Hi."

Everyone said hello.

She sat behind me.

At break, Noah walked over.

"You've got a new person behind you."

"I noticed."

"Think she's nice?"

"I've spoken to her for approximately three seconds."

"Good point."

Sophie walked over.

"You're Tim, right?"

"Yeah."

"You're the student council leader."

I nodded.

She smiled.

"Everyone talks about you."

I immediately became worried.

"What do they say?"

She laughed.

"Mostly that you're weird."

I looked at Noah.

He shrugged.

"Accurate."

At lunch, Sophie saw Greg.

"What is that?"

"That's Greg."

She picked him up.

"Why does your school have a rubber chicken?"

I explained everything.

She stared at me for a few seconds.

Then laughed.

"Okay."

"What?"

"I think I'm going to like this school."

Later that afternoon, Sophie asked if she could join the student council.

I was surprised.

"Why?"

She shrugged.

"I like organizing things."

I looked at Noah.

He nodded.

"She'll probably be more organized than you."

"Thanks."

So Sophie joined.

And within one day, she had already fixed three problems we'd been struggling with.

I wasn't sure whether I was impressed...

Or threatened.

CHAPTER 15

The Festival Committee

Thursday

The festival was getting closer.

Very close.

We had exactly two weeks.

And our planning was a mess.

The student council room looked like a tornado had hit it.

Posters everywhere.

Boxes everywhere.

Lists everywhere.

Greg was sitting on top of a pile of papers.

Sophie walked in.

She stared at the room.

"What happened?"

I pointed at Noah.

"He did it."

Noah pointed at me.

"He did it."

Sophie sighed.

"You're both useless."

"Fair."

She grabbed a marker.

"Okay. We're making a schedule."

For the next two hours, Sophie organized everything.

Food.

Games.

Music.

Sports.

Stalls.

Tickets.

Security.

Everything.

When she finished, we all stared at the schedule.

It was perfect.

Brad walked in.

"Wow."

Sophie looked at him.

"You're in charge of the sports tournament."

Brad smiled.

"Easy."

"You also need to find volunteers."

His smile disappeared.

"Uh..."

She handed him a list.

"Twenty people."

Brad stared at it.

"Twenty?"

"Yes."

He looked at me.

"Can I quit?"

"No."

THE BIG ANNOUNCEMENT

At the end of the day, we announced the festival plans.

The whole school was excited.

But then the principal made an announcement.

"Because this festival is larger than usual, we will be inviting parents and members of the community."

Everyone cheered.

Then he added:

"And there will be a special award for the student who contributes the most."

Brad looked at me.

I looked at Brad.

We both knew what was coming.

"You're not winning."

"Neither are you."

The rivalry was officially back.

CHAPTER 16

The Volunteer Problem

Friday

We needed volunteers.

A lot of volunteers.

Nobody wanted to volunteer.

I stood in front of my class.

"Who wants to help?"

Silence.

I tried again.

"It's for the festival."

Silence.

"You get free food."

Three hands went up.

I sighed.

"Okay. Better."

Brad walked into the classroom.

"I need twenty people for the sports tournament."

Everyone suddenly looked interested.

"Do they get to play?"

"Yes."

Every hand went up.

Brad smiled.

"Problem solved."

I stared at him.

"That's cheating."

"No, it's strategy."

Meanwhile, I had to organize the food stalls.

That turned out to be much harder than expected.

Everyone wanted something different.

Pizza.

Burgers.

Hot dogs.

Pancakes.

Candy.

Popcorn.

One kid asked for sushi.

"Why?"

"Because sushi is good."

"We're not selling sushi."

"Why?"

"Because I don't know how to make sushi."

He nodded.

"Fair."

By the end of the day, we had most of the volunteers.

But there was still one major problem.

We didn't have enough food.

Sophie checked the list.

"We need another supplier."

I raised my hand.

"I know someone."

Everyone looked at me.

"My uncle owns a pizza shop."

Noah smiled.

"Pizza?"

I nodded.

"Pizza."

Suddenly, I became everyone's favorite person.

CHAPTER 17

The Pizza Deal

Monday

I went to my uncle's pizza shop after school.

I explained the festival.

He listened.

Then he smiled.

"I'll give you a discount."

I nearly hugged him.

"How much?"

He told me.

It was a really good deal.

I called Sophie.

"We've got pizza!"

She cheered.

Then she asked:

"How many?"

I paused.

"I didn't ask."

There was silence.

"Tim."

"What?"

"You need to know how much pizza we're getting."

"Right."

I called my uncle again.

He could supply enough pizza for the festival.

But there was one condition.

We had to advertise his shop.

That seemed easy.

We made a giant sign.

PIZZA PROVIDED BY UNCLE TONY'S

Everything was going perfectly.

Until Brad saw it.

"You're getting special treatment?"

"No."

"Looks like it."

"You can find your own sponsor."

Brad smiled.

"I already did."

He handed me a flyer.

It was for a burger restaurant.

They were sponsoring his sports tournament.

I stared at him.

"You've got a sponsor?"

"Yep."

He grinned.

"Free burgers."

I stared at the flyer.

Then at him.

"Fine."

"Fine."

We walked away.

Noah watched us.

"You two are going to destroy this festival."

Sophie nodded.

"I think so too."

CHAPTER 18

The Festival Poster

Tuesday

We needed a poster.

A really good one.

Sophie wanted something professional.

Noah wanted something funny.

Brad wanted himself on it.

I wanted a giant picture of Greg.

We argued for almost an hour.

Finally, we combined everyone's ideas.

The poster showed:

The festival name

The date

Games

Food

Music

Sports

And Greg wearing a crown.

Brad looked at it.

"Why does the chicken have a crown?"

"Because he's the mascot."

"He looks ridiculous."

I pointed at Brad.

"So do you."

Brad laughed.

"Fair."

We printed hundreds of copies.

Then we discovered a problem.

The date was wrong.

We had printed:

SATURDAY, OCTOBER 42

I stared at the poster.

"October has 42 days?"

Noah looked at me.

"It does now."

Sophie put her head in her hands.

"We have to reprint everything."

THE PRINTING DISASTER

We spent the afternoon fixing the posters.

But when we finally printed them, the printer ran out of ink.

Then it jammed.

Then it started printing blank pages.

Then it printed one page that just said:

HELP

Nobody knew why.

I looked at Noah.

"This feels personal."

CHAPTER 19

The School Rumour

Wednesday

Something strange happened today.

Everyone was talking about the festival.

But not about the games.

Not about the food.

Not about Greg.

They were talking about a rumour.

Apparently, someone was planning to sabotage the festival.

At first, I didn't believe it.

Then I heard three different people talking about it.

I found Noah.

"Have you heard?"

"Yep."

"Who started it?"

"No idea."

We found Sophie.

She looked worried.

"If someone actually sabotages the festival, we could lose everything."

Brad joined us.

"Who's doing it?"

"We don't know."

Brad crossed his arms.

"We should find out."

I looked at him.

"You want to help?"

"Obviously."

For once, Brad wasn't joking.

We decided to investigate.

THE INVESTIGATION

We made a list of suspects.

There was:

The eighth-grade prankster.

The cafeteria guy.

A student who hated school events.

A teacher who didn't like loud music.

And Kyle.

We all looked at Kyle.

He looked offended.

"Why am I on the list?"

"You tried to sell your brother."

"That has nothing to do with this."

Fair enough.

We questioned everyone.

Nobody admitted anything.

Then, after school, I found something strange.

A note had been slipped under the student council door.

It said:

YOU SHOULD NOT HAVE STARTED THIS.

I stared at it.

Noah looked over my shoulder.

"That's creepy."

Brad took the note.

"We need to take this seriously."

I nodded.

The festival was only ten days away.

And now someone was threatening to ruin it.

CHAPTER 20

The Mystery Begins

Thursday

We decided not to tell the whole school about the note.

If we did, everyone would panic.

Instead, we kept investigating.

Sophie checked the student council room.

Noah checked the hallways.

Brad checked the sports equipment.

I checked the festival storage room.

Nothing.

Then I noticed something.

One of the boxes had been moved.

I opened it.

Inside were the decorations.

But one thing was missing.

The giant festival banner.

I ran to find the others.

"We've got a problem."

They followed me.

"The banner is gone."

Brad frowned.

"When did you last see it?"

"Yesterday."

Sophie thought.

"Who had access to this room?"

I started counting.

"Student council members."

"Teachers."

"The cleaners."

"And..."

I stopped.

Brad noticed.

"And who?"

I pointed toward the door.

"The sports team."

Everyone looked at Brad.

Brad looked offended.

"Why are you looking at me?"

"Because you're in charge of sports."

"I didn't take it."

"I didn't say you did."

Brad sighed.

"Fine. I'll help you find it."

We searched the entire school.

Nothing.

Then Noah suddenly shouted from the hallway.

"GUYS!"

We ran toward him.

He was standing beside a noticeboard.

There was a piece of paper pinned to it.

I pulled it off.

It was another note.

YOU HAVE NINE DAYS.

Underneath was a drawing.

A chicken.

But it wasn't Greg.

It was a chicken with a black X over its face.

I looked at Brad.

He looked at me.

For once, neither of us had a joke.

Someone really was trying to ruin the festival.

And now we had nine days to figure out who.

I folded the note and put it in my pocket.

"Okay," I said.

"We're solving this."

Brad nodded.

"Together."

Noah looked at us.

"This is probably the worst idea we've ever had."

Sophie smiled.

"Which means it might actually work."

I looked down the empty hallway.

Somewhere in the school was the person behind all of this.

And they weren't finished.

Not even close.

CHAPTER 21

The Missing Banner

Friday

There are two things I learned today.

First, being student council leader is a lot of work.

Second, whoever is trying to ruin the festival is getting really annoying.

We still hadn't found the missing banner.

We searched classrooms.

The sports storeroom.

The hall.

Even the teachers' lounge.

Nothing.

Then, during lunch, Noah came running toward me.

"TIM!"

I nearly dropped my sandwich.

"What?"

"I found something."

He pulled a piece of paper from his pocket.

It was a list.

I looked at it.

It was the schedule for the festival.

Someone had crossed out several activities.

The football tournament.

The concert.

The food stalls.

Even the talent show.

At the bottom someone had written:

ONE BY ONE.

I stared at it.

"Where did you find this?"

"Inside the student council room."

Sophie walked over.

"What happened?"

I showed her.

Her expression changed.

"Someone has been inside our room."

Brad joined us.

"Then we need to figure out who."

I nodded.

For the first time, this wasn't just a stupid prank.

Someone actually wanted the festival cancelled.

THE SUSPECTS

We made another list.

This time, we took it seriously.

Suspect 1: Kyle

He was always doing weird things.

Suspect 2: The eighth graders

They had been complaining about the festival.

Suspect 3: Someone from Riverdale

Maybe they were angry that we won the competition.

Suspect 4: A teacher

This was probably a terrible idea to write down.

Suspect 5: Someone on the student council

That possibility made me uncomfortable.

Because if the person was on the council...

They had access to everything.

I looked around the room.

There were only six of us.

Me.

Noah.

Sophie.

Brad.

Mia.

And Ethan.

I trusted all of them.

At least...

I thought I did.

CHAPTER 22

Security Team

Monday

We decided to create a security team.

Noah immediately volunteered.

"I'll be head of security."

I looked at him.

"You don't even know how to lock a door."

"That's why I'll learn."

Sophie gave us a list of rules.

No one enters the student council room alone.

All festival equipment gets locked up.

Every important document gets copied.

And most importantly:

Greg must remain safe.

I stared at the last rule.

"Why?"

Sophie pointed at the rubber chicken.

"Because someone already stole the banner."

I nodded.

"Fair."

Brad laughed.

"Imagine someone stealing the chicken."

I grabbed Greg.

"Don't even joke about that."

At break, we started guarding the festival equipment.

Everything was going fine.

Until Noah shouted:

"INTRUDER!"

I turned around.

A teacher was walking toward us.

"That's Mr. Peterson."

Noah lowered his arms.

"Oh."

Mr. Peterson looked at him.

"Why were you yelling?"

"Security reasons."

The teacher walked away.

I looked at Noah.

"You're fired."

THE REAL PROBLEM

After school, we checked the storage room.

Everything was there.

Except...

The microphones.

There were supposed to be six.

Now there were four.

I stared at the empty shelf.

"Someone took them."

Brad looked around.

"Maybe they were moved."

"No."

Sophie checked the inventory.

"Six microphones. Four here."

Noah whispered:

"That's not good."

I nodded.

The festival was getting closer.

And someone was slowly taking it apart.

CHAPTER 23

The Trap

Tuesday

We decided to set a trap.

The plan was simple.

We would leave something important in the student council room.

Then we'd hide nearby.

If someone came to steal it...

We'd catch them.

The bait was a box labeled:

FESTIVAL MONEY

It didn't actually contain money.

It contained old textbooks.

But nobody knew that.

We hid behind a stack of chairs.

Brad whispered:

"How long do we wait?"

"As long as it takes."

Five minutes passed.

Ten minutes.

Twenty minutes.

My legs were starting to hurt.

Noah whispered:

"I have to sneeze."

"Don't."

"I can't stop it."

"Don't!"

He sneezed.

ACHOO!

We all froze.

Nothing happened.

Then the door handle moved.

Someone was coming in.

I looked at Brad.

Brad looked at me.

The door opened.

A person wearing a hoodie walked into the room.

They looked around.

Then walked straight toward the box.

I jumped out.

"GOT YOU!"

The person screamed.

We screamed.

Noah screamed.

Brad screamed.

Then the person pulled off the hood.

It was...

Kyle.

I stared at him.

"KYLE?!"

He looked embarrassed.

"I thought there was money!"

"You were stealing?"

"No!"

He pointed at the box.

"I was going to borrow it."

"Why?"

"I wanted to buy chips."

Everyone stared at him.

Sophie sighed.

"You're not the saboteur."

Kyle looked relieved.

"Good."

Then he grabbed his backpack.

"Can I have some chips anyway?"

"No."

That night, I kept thinking about the hooded person.

If Kyle wasn't the saboteur...

Who was?

CHAPTER 24

The Strange Photograph

Wednesday

Sophie found something.

She brought it to me before class.

"Look."

It was an old photograph.

It showed the school festival from five years ago.

There was a huge crowd.

Lots of stalls.

A stage.

And...

A giant trophy.

"What is that?" I asked.

"The Festival Cup."

Apparently, every year the school used to award a trophy to the student who contributed the most.

Then the tradition stopped.

"Why?"

Sophie shrugged.

"I don't know."

We took the photo to the principal.

He looked surprised.

"Where did you find this?"

"In the archives."

He smiled.

"The Festival Cup."

"Why did you stop giving it out?"

He thought for a moment.

"Because the last one disappeared."

I stared at him.

"Someone stole it?"

"We don't know."

I looked at Sophie.

She looked at me.

The missing trophy.

The missing banner.

The threats.

It was all starting to feel connected.

THE ARCHIVES

That afternoon, we searched the old school records.

We found a newspaper article.

The headline said:

FESTIVAL TROPHY DISAPPEARS

Underneath was a photograph.

The trophy looked exactly like the one in the old picture.

But there was another detail.

In the corner of the photograph was a student wearing a dark hoodie.

His face was hidden.

I pointed at the picture.

"That's weird."

Brad leaned closer.

"Very weird."

Noah whispered:

"Maybe it's the same person."

Sophie shook her head.

"The photo is five years old."

"Right."

I looked at the picture again.

Then I noticed something.

On the wall behind the student was a poster.

It had the school logo.

And underneath it was a name.

THE BLACK HAWKS.

I had no idea what that meant.

But I had a feeling we were going to find out.

CHAPTER 25

The Black Hawks

Thursday

I asked the principal about the Black Hawks.

His expression changed immediately.

"You found that name?"

"Yes."

He sighed.

"The Black Hawks were a student group."

"What kind of group?"

"They organized school events years ago."

"Like the festival?"

"Exactly."

"Why aren't they around anymore?"

He looked uncomfortable.

"They had a disagreement with the school."

"What kind?"

He didn't answer.

That made me even more curious.

At lunch, we searched the library.

We found an old yearbook.

There was a picture of the Black Hawks.

Six students stood together.

Five boys.

One girl.

They were all wearing black jackets with a hawk symbol.

Underneath the picture was a quote:

"Nobody can stop us."

Brad frowned.

"That's creepy."

Noah pointed at one of the students.

"Wait."

"What?"

"Look at his name."

It was:

Daniel Cross.

Sophie shook her head.

"Do you know him?"

"No."

But I had heard the name before.

Somewhere.

I just couldn't remember where.

CHAPTER 26

The Mystery Man

Friday

We asked around about Daniel Cross.

Most students had never heard of him.

Then a teacher told us something.

"Daniel used to be one of the best students here."

"Where is he now?"

"He left the school."

"Why?"

The teacher paused.

"There was an argument about the festival."

"What happened?"

"He wanted the Black Hawks to control the entire event."

I looked at Brad.

"So he was angry?"

"Very."

The teacher continued.

"The school refused. After that, the Black Hawks disappeared."

That sounded suspicious.

Very suspicious.

THE PHONE CALL

That afternoon, I got a strange phone call.

The number was unknown.

I answered.

"Hello?"

Silence.

"Hello?"

Then a voice spoke.

"You should stop looking."

I froze.

"Who is this?"

"You don't want to know."

The call ended.

I stared at the phone.

Noah walked over.

"Who was that?"

"I don't know."

I told everyone what happened.

Brad looked angry.

"We're going to find him."

Sophie shook her head.

"We need to be careful."

I nodded.

But there was something else bothering me.

The voice sounded familiar.

Very familiar.

CHAPTER 27

The Locker

Monday

The next morning, my locker was open.

I was sure I'd locked it.

Inside was a note.

I opened it.

YOU'RE GETTING CLOSER.

Underneath was a number.

17

I showed Noah.

"What does seventeen mean?"

"Seventeen?"

"Yeah."

Sophie looked at it.

"Maybe it's a locker."

We checked locker 17.

It was empty.

Then Brad noticed something.

The lock was new.

He touched it.

"Someone changed this."

We told the principal.

He opened the locker.

Inside was a small box.

There was a key.

And another note.

THE PAST IS THE ANSWER.

I looked at everyone.

"What does that even mean?"

THE KEY

We tried the key on every door we could think of.

Nothing.

Then I remembered the old archives.

There was a locked cabinet there.

We went to check.

The key fit.

Inside was an old folder.

The label said:

FESTIVAL — YEAR FIVE

I opened it.

There were documents about the Black Hawks.

But one page had been ripped out.

Someone had deliberately removed it.

Brad clenched his fist.

"Whoever this is doesn't want us to know what happened."

I nodded.

And now I really wanted to know.

CHAPTER 28

The Missing Page

Tuesday

We spent the entire morning trying to find the missing page.

Eventually, Sophie found a copy.

It was in an old computer file.

We printed it.

The page explained what happened five years ago.

The Black Hawks had organized the festival.

But on the night before the event, the Festival Cup disappeared.

Everyone blamed Daniel Cross.

Daniel denied stealing it.

The school cancelled the Black Hawks after that.

But there was one strange detail.

The report said:

"The trophy was last seen in the principal's office."

I stared at the page.

"So Daniel didn't steal it."

"Apparently not," Sophie said.

Brad frowned.

"Then who did?"

We had no idea.

Then Noah pointed at the bottom of the page.

There was a handwritten note.

THE TROPHY WAS NEVER STOLEN.

I stared at it.

"What?"

Noah looked at me.

"It says it wasn't stolen."

"Then where did it go?"

We all went silent.

CHAPTER 29

The Trophy Room

Wednesday

There was one place we hadn't searched.

The old trophy room.

It had been closed for years.

The door was covered in dust.

Brad tried the handle.

Locked.

Sophie used the key from the archive.

CLICK.

The door opened.

Inside were shelves covered in old trophies.

Football.

Debate.

Science.

Music.

And then we saw it.

A large empty space on the top shelf.

A label underneath said:

FESTIVAL CUP

I walked closer.

"The trophy was here."

Brad nodded.

Then I noticed something on the floor.

A black feather.

I picked it up.

Noah stared at it.

"The Black Hawks."

Sophie looked around the room.

"Someone has been here recently."

There were footprints in the dust.

Fresh ones.

They led toward the back of the room.

We followed them.

They stopped at a wall.

There was nowhere else to go.

Brad touched the wall.

Nothing.

Then Noah noticed something.

"Wait."

He pointed at the floor.

One of the tiles was loose.

Brad pulled it up.

Underneath was a small metal box.

Inside was...

The Festival Cup.

We all stared at it.

"We found it."

I picked it up.

But then something happened.

The lights went out.

CLICK.

Complete darkness.

Then we heard the door slam.

BANG!

Someone had locked us inside.

CHAPTER 30

Locked In

Wednesday

"Okay."

I tried to stay calm.

"Nobody panic."

Noah immediately panicked.

"WE'RE GOING TO DIE!"

"We're not going to die."

"HOW DO YOU KNOW?"

"Because this is a school."

Brad tried the door.

Locked.

Sophie searched for another exit.

Nothing.

I pulled out my phone.

No signal.

Of course.

"Great."

We were trapped in the old trophy room.

With the Festival Cup.

And whoever had locked us inside was probably still somewhere nearby.

Then we heard footsteps outside.

Everyone went quiet.

Step.

Step.

Step.

Someone stopped outside the door.

A shadow appeared underneath it.

I held my breath.

Then a voice whispered:

"You should have left it alone."

Brad stepped toward the door.

"Who are you?"

Silence.

Then the footsteps disappeared.

We waited.

A minute passed.

Then another.

Finally, we heard the lock click.

The door opened.

Nobody was there.

We ran out.

THE PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE

We took the trophy straight to the principal.

He stared at it.

"I haven't seen this in five years."

I put it on his desk.

"Someone was hiding it."

He looked at the black feather.

His face went pale.

"You found this too?"

"Yes."

He sat down.

Then he said something that shocked all of us.

"The Black Hawks aren't the people you should be looking for."

I stared at him.

"Why?"

He looked toward the office door.

"Because one of them never left."

Nobody spoke.

"What do you mean?"

The principal lowered his voice.

"One of the original Black Hawks is still connected to this school."

I looked at Brad.

Brad looked at Sophie.

Sophie looked at Noah.

Then the principal said:

"And I think they're the person behind all of this."

My stomach dropped.

Someone on the inside.

Someone who had access to the school.

Someone who knew about the old festival.

Someone who had been watching us.

The mystery had just gotten a lot bigger.

And we had only five days until the festival.

CHAPTER 31

The Original Black Hawk

The principal closed the office door.

Nobody said anything.

That was usually a bad sign.

I looked at Noah.

Noah looked at Sophie.

Sophie looked at Brad.

Brad looked at Greg.

Greg looked like a rubber chicken.

So that didn't help.

The principal finally spoke.

"One of the original Black Hawks still has a connection to this school."

I swallowed.

"Like... a teacher?"

"Possibly."

Noah whispered, "What if it's the principal?"

The principal stared at him.

Noah immediately looked at the floor.

"I was just saying."

The principal told us there were six original Black Hawks. Daniel Cross was one of them.

But there were five others.

And nobody knew where all of them were now.

Sophie immediately asked for their names.

The principal hesitated.

Then he pulled out an old yearbook.

"These are the original members."

We looked at the photograph.

Daniel Cross.

Michael Reed.

Jason Miller.

Thomas Grant.

Oliver Stone.

And one girl whose name had been scratched out.

That was strange.

"Why is her name scratched out?" Sophie asked.

The principal didn't answer.

Then we heard a noise outside.

BANG!

Everyone jumped.

Brad opened the door.

Nobody was there.

Except for a black feather lying on the floor.

Noah picked it up.

"Okay," he said. "I'm officially uncomfortable."

I agreed.

And for the first time, I started wondering if we were dealing with someone who knew EVERYTHING about the old Black Hawks.

CHAPTER 32

The Suspect List

Sophie decided we needed a suspect list.

She made a huge chart.

At the top she wrote:

WHO IS THE BLACK HAWK?

Underneath were six names.

Daniel Cross.

Michael Reed.

Jason Miller.

Thomas Grant.

Oliver Stone.

And...

"What's the girl's name?" I asked.

"The principal doesn't know," Sophie said.

"How can he not know?"

"Because someone scratched it out."

Noah leaned over the paper.

"Maybe the feather person is actually a giant bird."

We stared at him.

"What?" he said. "We're considering every possibility."

We started investigating.

Michael Reed had moved to another city.

Jason Miller supposedly worked at a sports company.

Thomas Grant was a doctor.

Oliver Stone owned a business.

Daniel Cross was the only one we knew almost nothing about.

That made him the obvious suspect.

Which meant he was probably NOT the obvious suspect.

At least that's what happens in mystery movies.

I told everyone we should find Daniel Cross.

Brad nodded.

"I'll help."

I looked at him.

"Really?"

"Yeah."

"Why?"

"Because if there's a mystery, I want to solve it before you do."

There was the Brad I knew.

We shook hands.

Sophie sighed.

"This is going to be exhausting."

She was right.

CHAPTER 33

The Old School Map

Sophie found something in the archives.

An old school map.

But it wasn't the same as our current school.

There were rooms that didn't exist anymore.

One room caught my attention.

BLACK HAWK STORAGE

I pointed at it.

"What's that?"

Sophie studied the map.

"It's underneath the old gym."

Noah's eyes widened.

"Secret underground room."

Brad smiled.

"Now we're talking."

The problem was that the old gym had been demolished years ago.

Or at least that's what the principal told us.

We went outside and looked at the area where the gym used to be.

There was now a storage building.

I walked around it.

Nothing.

Then Greg fell out of my backpack.

I had forgotten I put him in there.

He landed on the ground.

BONK.

Something underneath the floor made a hollow sound.

I froze.

I knocked again.

BONK.

Noah looked at me.

"Did you just discover a secret tunnel with a chicken?"

"I think so."

Brad started searching the floor.

We eventually found a loose metal plate.

Underneath it was a ladder.

Sophie looked down.

"There's definitely something underneath."

Noah shook his head.

"Nope."

I looked at him.

"You don't want to go?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because every time we find a secret room, something terrible happens."

I climbed down.

Brad followed.

Sophie followed.

Noah sighed.

Then followed us.

"Fine."

CHAPTER 34

The Hidden Room

The ladder led to a small underground room.

There were dusty shelves everywhere.

Old boxes.

Old posters.

Old sports equipment.

And on the wall...

A giant black hawk symbol.

Nobody spoke.

Then Brad said, "Okay, that's creepy."

We found a box labeled:

FESTIVAL — BLACK HAWKS

Inside were old papers.

There were festival schedules.

Rules.

Budgets.

Photos.

And a notebook.

I opened it.

Most of the pages were blank.

But one page had writing on it.

THE FESTIVAL BELONGS TO US.

Underneath was another sentence.

IF THEY TAKE IT AWAY, WE TAKE IT BACK.

Noah looked nervous.

"Who are 'they'?"

Sophie pointed at another page.

There was a list of names.

All six Black Hawks.

Then beside Daniel Cross's name was a big red X.

Brad frowned.

"Why would someone cross him out?"

Before we could answer, we heard footsteps above us.

Someone was walking around the storage building.

We turned off our flashlight.

The footsteps stopped.

Then started again.

Closer.

Noah whispered:

"I really hope that's a teacher."

The door above us opened.

A shadow appeared.

Someone was standing directly over the entrance.

Then the door slammed shut.

We were trapped.

Again.

CHAPTER 35

Escape Plan

We tried the ladder.

It didn't move.

Brad pushed it.

Nothing.

Noah pushed it.

Nothing.

I pushed it.

Nothing.

Sophie looked at us.

"Move."

She kicked the side of the ladder.

Nothing happened.

She kicked it again.

Still nothing.

Noah stared at her.

"That was impressive."

"Thank you."

"It didn't work."

"I know."

We searched the room.

There had to be another exit.

Eventually Sophie noticed a small hole behind one of the shelves.

She moved the shelf.

Behind it was a narrow tunnel.

"Found it."

Noah stared into it.

"How narrow?"

"Very."

Brad looked at me.

"You first."

"Why me?"

"Because you're the leader."

"That's not how leadership works!"

It turned out the tunnel was barely wide enough for us.

I crawled through.

After about thirty seconds, I reached another room.

I stood up.

Then immediately hit my head on a pipe.

CLANG!

Noah crawled out behind me.

"Are you okay?"

"Yes."

I rubbed my head.

"Absolutely."

We eventually escaped through an old maintenance door.

When we got outside, the storage building was empty.

Whoever had locked us in was gone.

But there was something on the ground.

A note.

I picked it up.

It said:

YOU FOUND THE ROOM.

Then underneath:

NOW FIND OUT WHY IT WAS HIDDEN.

CHAPTER 36

The Worst Lunch Ever

After everything that happened, I decided I deserved a normal school day.

So naturally, lunch went terribly.

I sat down with Noah, Sophie and Brad.

I opened my lunchbox.

Inside was a sandwich.

I took one bite.

Then I noticed everyone staring at me.

"What?"

Brad pointed at my sandwich.

"What is that?"

"It's a sandwich."

"No. That's a science experiment."

I looked at it.

The cheese had somehow turned green.

Noah leaned closer.

"It might be alive."

I dropped it.

It landed on the table.

SPLAT.

Sophie stared at it.

"How long has that been in there?"

"Maybe three days."

"TIM!"

"I forgot!"

Brad laughed.

Then he challenged me to eat the rest.

"No."

"Scared?"

"No."

"Chicken?"

I looked at Greg sitting on the table.

Then I looked at the sandwich.

"No amount of peer pressure is getting me to eat that."

Noah nodded.

"Good."

Then the sandwich moved.

Everyone screamed.

It turned out the movement was caused by the table shaking.

But for about five seconds, we genuinely thought my sandwich had become a monster.

The principal walked past.

He looked at the sandwich.

Then at us.

Then kept walking.

I think he has learned not to ask questions anymore.

CHAPTER 37

Daniel Cross

Sophie managed to find something about Daniel Cross.

An old address.

Not a current one.

But it was a starting point.

We showed it to the principal.

He immediately became serious.

"Don't go there."

That made us even more curious.

"Why?" I asked.

"Because you don't know what you're getting involved in."

Brad crossed his arms.

"Then tell us."

The principal sighed.

He explained that Daniel Cross had blamed the school after the Festival Cup disappeared.

He believed the school had covered something up.

Then Daniel left.

Nobody heard from him for years.

But there was one strange thing.

The principal had received a letter from Daniel recently.

"What did it say?" Sophie asked.

The principal looked at us.

"He said..."

He paused.

"'The truth is still underneath the school.'"

Everyone went quiet.

Noah whispered:

"Underneath the school?"

I immediately thought about the secret room.

Maybe the room wasn't the end.

Maybe it was only the beginning.

CHAPTER 38

The School Gets Watched

The next morning, things got weird.

A black car was parked across from the school.

Nobody knew who it belonged to.

Sophie noticed it first.

"It's been there for three days."

I looked through the window.

The car was completely black.

The windows were dark.

Brad wanted to go outside and investigate.

Sophie stopped him.

"We don't even know if it's connected."

Brad sighed.

"Fine."

At lunch, the car was still there.

After school, it was still there.

Then, just as we were leaving...

The car drove away.

Noah looked relieved.

"Good."

I nodded.

Then Sophie pointed at the ground.

There was another black feather.

Under it was a tiny piece of paper.

I unfolded it.

There was only one sentence:

STOP DIGGING.

Brad looked angry.

"I'm done being told what to do."

I looked at him.

"You realize that's exactly what the note wants us to do, right?"

He paused.

"Oh."

Sophie smiled.

"He's learning."

CHAPTER 39

The Festival Disaster

We had completely forgotten something important.

The festival was only three days away.

And half the equipment still wasn't ready.

The microphones were missing.

Some decorations hadn't arrived.

The sports equipment was incomplete.

The food stalls weren't organized.

And the stage lights weren't working.

Sophie looked at the checklist.

"We have a problem."

Noah looked over her shoulder.

"We have several problems."

I grabbed the microphone.

It didn't work.

I tapped it.

"Hello?"

Nothing.

I tapped it again.

The speaker suddenly made a horrible screech.

EEEEEEEEEEEEEEEE!

Everyone covered their ears.

The microphone exploded into a cloud of dust.

Brad stared at me.

"What did you do?"

"I don't know!"

Sophie checked the cable.

"It wasn't plugged in."

I looked at her.

"So..."

She sighed.

"So you were yelling into a microphone that wasn't connected."

"Exactly."

"That doesn't explain the explosion."

"Maybe it was scared."

By the end of the day, we had fixed almost everything.

Almost.

Then we discovered the stage had been vandalized.

Someone had painted a black hawk on the back wall.

And underneath it were four words:

THE FESTIVAL IS MINE.

CHAPTER 40

Three Days Left

The festival was three days away.

The mystery was getting bigger.

And we had no idea who was behind it.

The principal called an emergency meeting.

Everyone from student council sat around the table.

Mia.

Ethan.

Kyle.

Sophie.

Noah.

Brad.

And me.

The principal placed the Festival Cup in the middle.

"We need to keep this safe."

Kyle raised his hand.

"Can I ask something?"

"What?"

"Why don't we just put it somewhere nobody knows about?"

Sophie stared at him.

"That's actually a good idea."

Kyle smiled.

"I have good ideas sometimes."

Noah whispered, "Rarely."

The principal agreed.

The trophy would be moved to a secret location.

Only three people would know where it was.

Me.

Sophie.

And the principal.

Then Brad stood up.

"I don't like this."

"What?"

"Someone is clearly watching us. If they know where the trophy is, they'll come after it."

I nodded.

"Then we'll protect it."

Brad smiled.

"Good."

Noah looked worried.

"Protect it how?"

I thought for a second.

Then I had an idea.

"We set a trap."

Sophie immediately shook her head.

"No."

"But—"

"No."

"What if it's a really good trap?"

"No."

"What if—"

"Tim."

"Okay."

I sat back down.

Then, from somewhere outside the room, we heard three knocks.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Everyone froze.

The principal slowly walked to the door.

He opened it.

Nobody was there.

Only a black feather.

And underneath it...

A key.

Attached to the key was a tiny label.

ROOM 75.

CHAPTER 41

Room 75

The key had a label.

ROOM 75.

There was just one problem.

Our school didn't have a Room 75.

At least, not anymore.

Sophie grabbed the old school map.

She ran her finger across it.

"Wait."

"What?"

She pointed at the map.

"Room 75 used to exist."

I leaned closer.

It was located somewhere near the old gym.

Which was now the storage building.

Noah immediately shook his head.

"No."

"What?"

"We are NOT going underground again."

Brad smiled.

"Sounds like we're going underground again."

Noah looked at me.

"Please tell me you're going to be responsible."

I thought about it.

"Absolutely."

Noah smiled.

"Great."

"We'll go after school."

His smile disappeared.

"I knew it."

After the final bell, we went to the storage building.

Sophie held the key.

We found an old metal door hidden behind some shelves.

There was a number above it.

75.

Sophie inserted the key.

CLICK.

The door opened.

Inside was a tiny room covered in dust.

There was one desk.

One chair.

And one old computer.

On the desk was a folder.

Written across it were four words:

BLACK HAWK — FINAL PLAN

Nobody touched it.

Then Noah whispered:

"Maybe we should just go home."

For once, I agreed.

CHAPTER 42

The Final Plan

We opened the folder.

The first page was an old festival schedule.

The second was a map.

The third was a list of names.

But the fourth page was different.

It had a giant black hawk drawn across it.

Underneath were the words:

PHASE ONE — REMOVE THE FESTIVAL EQUIPMENT.

We looked at each other.

That was exactly what had been happening.

Then:

PHASE TWO — FIND THE CUP.

My stomach dropped.

They had been looking for the Festival Cup.

Then came:

PHASE THREE — CANCEL THE FESTIVAL.

Brad slammed his hand on the desk.

"They're trying to cancel the festival!"

Sophie continued reading.

But the next page had been ripped out.

Of course it had.

I was starting to hate missing pages.

Noah pointed at the computer.

"Maybe there's something on there."

I pressed the power button.

Nothing.

I pressed it again.

Still nothing.

I hit it.

The computer suddenly turned on.

Everyone jumped.

The screen showed one message.

WELCOME BACK.

Noah stared at me.

"Did you just break into an old computer?"

"I may have encouraged it."

The screen changed.

PHASE FOUR — ???

Then the computer shut off.

A second later, we heard footsteps outside.

Someone was coming.

CHAPTER 43

The Chase

We grabbed the folder.

"Go!" Brad shouted.

We ran out of Room 75.

Someone was coming down the hallway.

I couldn't see their face.

They were wearing a black hoodie.

We ran faster.

Noah nearly crashed into a wall.

"I'M TOO YOUNG FOR THIS!"

We turned a corner.

The person followed us.

Brad stopped.

"We should confront them."

Sophie grabbed his arm.

"No!"

We ran toward the exit.

The person was getting closer.

I looked behind me.

They were holding something.

A black folder.

"HEY!"

They stopped.

Then threw the folder at us.

It landed on the floor.

By the time we reached the door, they were gone.

Brad ran outside.

Nothing.

No car.

No person.

Nothing.

Sophie picked up the folder.

Inside was a single photograph.

It showed the original Black Hawks.

But there was something strange.

Someone had been standing behind them.

A seventh person.

Their face had been scratched out.

Noah stared at it.

"Seven?"

Sophie nodded.

"There were supposed to be six."

I looked at the photograph.

"Then who was the seventh?"

Nobody knew.

CHAPTER 44

The Seventh Black Hawk

We took the photograph to the principal.

The moment he saw it, his face changed.

"You found this?"

"Yes."

"Where?"

"Room 75."

He sat down.

For a few seconds, he didn't say anything.

Then he finally spoke.

"There was never supposed to be a seventh member."

"But there is one," Sophie said.

The principal shook his head.

"No."

He turned the photograph over.

There was writing on the back.

WE WERE SEVEN.

Underneath:

ONE OF US WAS NEVER COUNTED.

Noah looked confused.

"How can someone be a member if they weren't counted?"

The principal didn't answer.

Then Brad noticed something.

The seventh person was wearing a school uniform.

Not an old Black Hawks jacket.

A normal school uniform.

"Maybe they weren't a Black Hawk yet," Brad said.

Sophie looked at the picture.

"Maybe they were a student who helped them."

The principal took the photograph.

"You shouldn't be involved in this anymore."

I stood up.

"We can't stop now."

The principal looked at me.

"Tim..."

"I know we're supposed to be organizing a festival."

I pointed at the photo.

"But someone is trying to destroy it."

He didn't argue.

That worried me more than anything.

CHAPTER 45

Festival Practice

We decided to take one day off from the mystery.

We needed to prepare for the festival.

The school gym was packed with students practicing their performances.

There were dancers.

Singers.

A magician.

A kid who could juggle.

And me.

I was supposed to be helping with the opening ceremony.

Instead, I was practicing my weird noises.

Noah walked in.

"Please tell me you're not doing that at the festival."

"Maybe."

"Tim."

"I need an opening ceremony."

"You could say hello."

"That's boring."

Brad walked past.

"I think the chicken should open it."

He held up Frank.

I held up Greg.

"No."

Brad grinned.

"Chicken battle?"

"Not today."

Five minutes later, we were having a chicken battle.

Greg and Frank were placed on the gym floor.

Brad and I took turns making them "fight."

Sophie walked in.

She stared at us.

"You have three days to prepare a school festival."

"Yes."

"And you're doing this?"

"Yes."

She sighed.

Then she picked up Greg.

"Fine. Greg wins."

I smiled.

"Thank you."

Brad picked up Frank.

"This isn't over."

It never was.

CHAPTER 46

Someone Cuts the Power

That afternoon, the lights suddenly went out.

The entire school went dark.

Students screamed.

Someone knocked over a table.

Then the emergency lights came on.

Sophie looked at me.

"This isn't normal."

The principal rushed into the gym.

"The power has been cut."

Brad looked toward the equipment room.

"That's where the festival equipment is."

We ran.

The door was open.

Inside, several boxes had been moved.

The speakers were unplugged.

The microphones were gone.

Again.

Someone had stolen them.

On the floor was another black feather.

And beside it was a message.

TWO DAYS.

Noah read it.

"Two days until the festival."

I nodded.

The person wasn't just trying to scare us anymore.

They were running out of time.

And so were we.

CHAPTER 47

The Security Plan

Sophie took control.

She drew a giant map of the school.

"We're going to watch every entrance."

Brad nodded.

"I'll take the gym."

"Mia can watch the food area," Sophie continued.

"Ethan can watch the stage."

"Noah?"

Noah raised his hand.

"I'll watch the snacks."

Sophie stared at him.

"Why?"

"Because someone might steal them."

"Fine."

I looked at the map.

"What about me?"

Sophie handed me a walkie-talkie.

"You're staying in the student council room."

"Why?"

"Because you're the leader."

"That's boring."

"Exactly."

For once, everyone followed the plan.

For two hours, nothing happened.

Then my walkie-talkie made a noise.

CRACKLE.

Brad's voice came through.

"Tim."

"What?"

"I found something."

"What?"

"Come to the gym."

I ran.

Brad was standing beside the stage.

There was a small envelope on the floor.

He opened it.

Inside was a photograph.

It showed the school from five years ago.

On the back was a message:

LOOK AT THE CLOCK.

We looked at the giant clock above the stage.

It had stopped at exactly 7:15.

CHAPTER 48

7:15

We searched the school records.

7:15.

Nothing.

Then Sophie remembered something.

"The Festival Cup disappeared at 7:15."

Everyone went silent.

That couldn't be a coincidence.

We searched the old festival schedule.

At 7:15, the Black Hawks had a meeting.

Location:

ROOM 75.

Noah stared at the paper.

"So the trophy disappeared while they were in Room 75?"

"Maybe," Sophie said.

Brad pointed at the clock.

"Then why stop it at 7:15?"

I didn't know.

We returned to Room 75.

The old clock in the room was still working.

It read 6:52.

Then something fell from behind the desk.

A tiny metal object.

Sophie picked it up.

It looked like a key.

But this key was different.

It had a number.

7:15.

Noah looked at it.

"That's not a room number."

Brad nodded.

"Then what is it?"

I looked around the room.

There was a small metal panel in the wall.

It had no handle.

Just a keyhole.

I inserted the key.

CLICK.

The wall moved.

Behind it was a narrow compartment.

Inside was an old cassette tape.

On the label were three words:

THE NIGHT EVERYTHING CHANGED.

CHAPTER 49

The Tape

We found an old tape player in the archive room.

Luckily, it still worked.

I pressed play.

At first, there was only static.

Then voices.

Young voices.

The Black Hawks.

We could hear them talking about the festival.

Then one voice became louder.

Daniel Cross.

"This isn't right."

Another voice answered.

"We already decided."

Daniel sounded angry.

"You can't do this."

There was shouting.

Then a loud bang.

The recording became distorted.

A few seconds later, someone said:

"Hide the cup."

We all froze.

Noah whispered:

"Who said that?"

The recording continued.

Then another voice said:

"Nobody can know what happened."

The tape ended.

Sophie rewound it.

We listened again.

The voice was still impossible to identify.

Brad looked at me.

"Daniel didn't steal the trophy."

"No," I said.

"Then someone else did."

Sophie nodded.

"And the school covered it up."

That meant the story we'd been told for five years was wrong.

Daniel Cross hadn't been the thief.

He might have been the person trying to expose the truth.

Then the tape player suddenly clicked.

It started playing again.

But we hadn't pressed anything.

A new voice came through.

It whispered:

"You're almost there."

The tape stopped.

Nobody moved.

CHAPTER 50

The Festival Eve

Tomorrow was the festival.

And we had a much bigger problem than missing microphones.

We had discovered that the Festival Cup mystery had been covered up.

Daniel Cross might have been innocent.

There was a seventh person.

And someone was still following us.

The principal called us into his office.

He looked exhausted.

"I owe you an explanation."

He opened a drawer.

Inside was an old black jacket.

The Black Hawks symbol was stitched onto it.

"Where did you get that?" I asked.

"I was there."

We stared at him.

"What?"

The principal sighed.

"Five years ago, I was the teacher supervising the Black Hawks."

Noah's mouth dropped open.

"So you knew them?"

"Yes."

"All six?"

The principal looked down.

"Seven."

Sophie leaned forward.

"You knew about the seventh person?"

He nodded.

"Yes."

"Who were they?"

The principal hesitated.

Before he could answer, every light in the school went out.

Again.

Then the fire alarm started screaming.

BEEP! BEEP! BEEP!

Students began shouting outside.

The principal ran to the door.

I followed.

Brad and Sophie followed me.

Noah was behind us.

"What happened?"

Nobody knew.

Then someone shouted from the hallway:

"THE FESTIVAL CUP IS GONE!"

We ran toward the display case.

The glass was broken.

The Festival Cup had disappeared.

And on the floor was one final black feather.

Underneath it was a note.

I picked it up.

It said:

SEE YOU AT THE FESTIVAL.

Tomorrow was the festival.

And whoever was behind this had just made their biggest move yet.

CHAPTER 51

The Festival That Almost Didn't Happen

The festival was supposed to start at 9:00.

It was 8:43.

And the Festival Cup was gone.

The principal stood in the middle of the hallway looking like he hadn't slept in about three years.

"Nobody panic."

Everyone immediately panicked.

Students were running around.

Teachers were trying to organize everyone.

The stage lights weren't working.

The microphones were missing.

And now the trophy was gone.

I looked at Sophie.

"We need a plan."

She nodded.

"We have 17 minutes."

"Why 17?"

"Because it's 8:43."

"Oh."

Brad walked over.

"I found the microphones."

I nearly fell over.

"WHAT?"

"They were in the sports equipment room."

"Why?"

Brad held up a note.

"Someone put them there."

The note said:

YOU'RE LOOKING IN THE WRONG PLACE.

Sophie took it.

"This is a distraction."

She was right.

Someone had stolen the microphones just to make us waste time looking for them.

Then Ethan came running toward us.

"The stage lights are working!"

Mia appeared behind him.

"The food stalls are ready!"

Noah came running next.

"I found Greg!"

I stared at him.

"Why was Greg missing?"

Noah shrugged.

"He was behind the curtains."

I looked at Greg.

For some reason, he had a tiny black feather stuck to his wing.

That made me nervous.

"Okay," I said.

"The festival is still happening."

Brad smiled.

"Then let's do this."

At exactly 9:00, the doors opened.

And the biggest festival our school had ever had officially began.

CHAPTER 52

The Festival Begins

The school was packed.

Parents.

Students.

Teachers.

Even people from other schools.

The food stalls were selling everything.

Pizza.

Burgers.

Pancakes.

Popcorn.

Candy.

And something Kyle called a "mystery sandwich."

Nobody knew what was inside it.

Nobody wanted to know.

The sports tournament started.

Brad was running around like he had been training for this his entire life.

Sophie was checking schedules.

Mia was managing the food stalls.

Ethan was controlling the stage.

Noah was supposed to be helping with security.

Instead, I found him eating popcorn.

"You're supposed to be watching the entrance."

"I am."

"You're facing the popcorn."

"The popcorn is suspicious."

I walked away.

Then I heard cheering.

The first performance had started.

A group of students were dancing on stage.

Everyone was having fun.

For a few minutes, I forgot about the mystery.

Then I noticed something.

A person standing at the back of the crowd.

Black hoodie.

Watching the stage.

I walked toward them.

They turned around.

I followed.

They disappeared around a corner.

I ran after them.

Nothing.

Just another black feather.

I picked it up.

Then I heard someone behind me.

"Looking for me?"

I turned around.

It wasn't the hooded person.

It was Daniel Cross.

CHAPTER 53

Daniel Cross

I stared at him.

He looked older than I expected.

He wasn't wearing a black hoodie.

He was wearing a normal jacket.

"You know who I am," he said.

"Daniel Cross?"

He nodded.

I called Sophie and Brad.

Within thirty seconds, all of us were standing there.

Daniel looked at the four of us.

"You shouldn't be investigating this."

Sophie crossed her arms.

"Everyone keeps telling us that."

Daniel smiled slightly.

"Then you probably understand why I'm here."

Brad stepped forward.

"Did you steal the Festival Cup?"

Daniel shook his head.

"No."

"Did you steal the equipment?"

"No."

"Are you the Black Hawk?"

Daniel paused.

"I was."

Noah looked confused.

"Then why are you helping us?"

Daniel looked toward the festival.

"Because five years ago, I tried to stop them."

"Stop who?"

"The others."

He explained that the Black Hawks had planned something during the old festival.

He disagreed with them.

The argument became serious.

And then the Festival Cup disappeared.

Daniel was blamed.

He left the school soon afterward.

"But who stole it?" Sophie asked.

Daniel looked at her.

"I don't know."

"Then why come back?"

He reached into his pocket.

He pulled out an old photograph.

It showed the Black Hawks again.

But this time, the seventh person wasn't scratched out.

Daniel pointed at them.

"Because I finally found out who this is."

CHAPTER 54

The Seventh Person

We stared at the photograph.

The seventh person was a student.

A girl.

She was standing behind the Black Hawks.

Daniel said her name.

"Emily Hart."

Nobody recognized the name.

"Was she a Black Hawk?" Sophie asked.

"Not officially."

"Then why was she there?"

Daniel looked away.

"Because she was the person who started everything."

Noah looked nervous.

"Started what?"

Daniel explained.

Emily had been one of the smartest students at the school.

She helped the Black Hawks organize festivals.

But she believed the school treated students unfairly.

She wanted the students to have control of the festival.

The Black Hawks agreed.

At first.

Then things changed.

Emily created a plan to take control of the Festival Cup ceremony.

But Daniel refused to help.

He said the plan had gone too far.

"What happened to Emily?" I asked.

Daniel shook his head.

"She disappeared."

"Where?"

"I don't know."

Sophie looked at the photograph.

"If she disappeared five years ago, how could she be behind this now?"

Daniel didn't answer.

Then he looked directly at me.

"That's what you need to find out."

Suddenly, the school bell rang.

Everyone jumped.

Daniel smiled.

"Enjoy your festival."

Then he walked away.

Brad watched him leave.

"Do you trust him?"

"No," Sophie said.

I looked at the photograph.

"Not yet."

CHAPTER 55

The Treasure Hunt

We decided we needed a break from the mystery.

Luckily, the festival had a treasure hunt.

The winning team got a giant box of chocolate.

Noah immediately joined.

"I'm solving this."

"You can't even solve a two-piece puzzle."

"This is different."

The first clue was:

I HAVE FOUR LEGS BUT NEVER WALK.

We ran around the school.

Table.

Chair.

Desk.

Bench.

Finally, Noah shouted:

"CHAIR!"

We checked underneath a chair.

There was another clue.

I HAVE A FACE BUT NO EYES.

Brad immediately said:

"Clock."

We found the next clue behind the clock.

Then:

I CAN RUN BUT NEVER WALK.

"Water!" Sophie said.

We ran to the fountain.

Another clue.

It eventually led us around the entire school.

Finally, we reached the last clue.

WHERE THE OLD HAWK WATCHES.

We all stopped.

There was only one place that could mean.

The old school emblem.

We ran to the hallway.

Behind the emblem was a small envelope.

Inside was the final clue.

But this wasn't part of the treasure hunt.

It said:

ROOM 75 WASN'T THE FIRST SECRET ROOM.

Noah looked at me.

"Why can't we just win chocolate?"

I sighed.

"Because apparently our lives are a mystery novel now."

CHAPTER 56

The Old Hawk

We searched the school emblem.

Behind it was a small metal box.

Inside was another key.

This one had a symbol instead of a number.

A hawk.

Sophie immediately recognized it.

"That's the original Black Hawks symbol."

Brad looked around.

"Where does it go?"

We searched the old school map.

There was another room.

But this room had no number.

It was marked with a small hawk.

We found it behind the old library.

There was a door hidden behind a bookshelf.

I pushed it.

Nothing.

Brad pushed.

Nothing.

Noah pushed.

Nothing.

Sophie looked at the lock.

"It's not locked."

"Then why won't it open?"

She examined the bookshelf.

"Because it's supposed to slide."

Brad grabbed the shelf.

Together, we moved it.

The door opened.

Inside was a room filled with boxes.

Old school newspapers.

Photos.

Trophies.

And a giant board covered with names.

Some names had been crossed out.

Some had circles around them.

Then I saw mine.

TIM

Underneath was a date.

3 WEEKS AGO.

I stared at it.

"What?"

Sophie looked at the board.

Her name was there too.

So was Noah's.

Brad's.

Mia's.

Ethan's.

Kyle's.

Everyone involved in the festival was on the board.

Someone had been watching us before we even knew there was a mystery.

CHAPTER 57

Someone Planned This

We searched the room.

There were files on every member of the student council.

Tim.

Noah.

Sophie.

Brad.

Mia.

Ethan.

Kyle.

Even the principal.

Someone had been collecting information about us.

Then Sophie found a folder labeled:

FESTIVAL 2026

Inside were plans for the festival.

Our plans.

The exact schedule.

The food stalls.

The sports tournament.

Everything.

I looked at Sophie.

"How did they know all this?"

She shook her head.

"Someone must have access to our planning documents."

Brad looked angry.

"So someone at the school is helping them."

Noah looked around.

"Maybe we should leave."

Suddenly, the door slammed.

We all jumped.

Brad ran to it.

Locked.

Again.

I was beginning to think doors were our greatest enemy.

Sophie searched the room.

"There's another exit."

She pointed toward the back.

We opened it.

It led into the library.

Before leaving, I looked back at the board.

There was one name we hadn't noticed.

It was written at the very top.

EMILY HART.

Beside her name was a single word:

RETURNED.

CHAPTER 58

The Wrong Person

We told the principal everything.

He looked shocked when we mentioned Emily.

"That's impossible."

"Why?"

"Emily Hart moved away."

"When?"

"Five years ago."

"Where?"

"I don't know."

Sophie frowned.

"Then how could someone write 'returned'?"

The principal didn't answer.

Brad immediately suspected him.

"You knew about Emily."

"Yes."

"You knew about the seventh Black Hawk."

The principal nodded.

"Yes."

"And you didn't tell us."

"I was trying to protect you."

Brad shook his head.

"Or hide something."

The principal looked angry.

"You don't understand what happened."

"Then explain it."

The principal sat down.

"Emily wasn't trying to destroy the festival."

Everyone froze.

"What?"

"She was trying to expose something."

"Expose what?"

The principal looked at the Festival Cup display case.

"The reason the trophy disappeared."

He finally admitted something.

Five years ago, the trophy wasn't stolen.

It was hidden.

The Black Hawks hid it because they discovered someone had been using the festival money for something they weren't supposed to.

"Who?"

The principal shook his head.

"I never found out."

Then the office door opened.

A teacher walked in.

"Principal?"

Everyone turned.

It was one of the teachers who had been helping organize the festival.

She looked at us.

Then at the principal.

Then she quietly said:

"Emily is back."

CHAPTER 59

The Message

The teacher said she had received a message that morning.

It was from an unknown number.

It contained only three words:

I AM BACK.

Underneath was a photograph.

Emily Hart.

Older.

Standing outside the school.

The message had been sent at 7:15.

The same time as the Festival Cup disappearance five years ago.

Noah looked terrified.

"Okay."

He pointed toward the window.

"I think that's her."

We all looked.

Across the school grounds was a woman standing near the gate.

She was holding something.

A black folder.

Then she turned around and walked away.

Brad ran toward the door.

"Wait!"

We chased after her.

But when we reached the gate, she was gone.

There was only the folder.

I opened it.

Inside was a letter.

It wasn't addressed to the principal.

It wasn't addressed to Daniel.

It was addressed to me.

TIM.

My hands started shaking.

I opened it.

The first sentence said:

You have been looking for the wrong person.

The second sentence was even worse.

The person helping you is the one you should fear.

CHAPTER 60

The Person Helping Us

We stood around the letter.

Nobody spoke.

Noah finally broke the silence.

"So... who is helping us?"

Sophie looked at everyone.

The principal.

Daniel.

The teachers.

The student council.

Even Brad.

Anyone could be involved.

Brad looked at me.

"Do you think it's me?"

"No."

"Good."

He smiled.

Then he pointed at Noah.

"Check him."

"What?!"

Noah looked offended.

"I have been loyal!"

Sophie laughed.

"You're probably too lazy to be a secret villain."

"Thank you."

"That wasn't a compliment."

I looked at the letter again.

There was one final line.

TRUST NO ONE UNTIL YOU FIND THE CUP.

Then I noticed something strange.

The handwriting.

It looked familiar.

Very familiar.

I had seen it before.

I just couldn't remember where.

Sophie noticed me staring.

"What?"

"I know this handwriting."

"Whose?"

I thought about it.

Then I remembered.

The note from Room 75.

The note under the trophy.

The note telling us to stop digging.

They all had the same handwriting.

But there was one more thing.

The handwriting looked exactly like the handwriting on the old Black Hawks documents.

Someone had been copying the same handwriting for five years.

Or...

The person who wrote those notes had access to the original documents.

I turned the letter over.

There was a final message.

THE CUP IS STILL INSIDE THE SCHOOL.

Then underneath:

AND YOU HAVE ALREADY WALKED PAST IT.

CHAPTER 61

We Already Walked Past It

"The cup is still inside the school."

I read the message again.

"And we've already walked past it."

Noah looked around.

"Okay. Where?"

"I don't know."

"Great."

Sophie took the letter.

"Think about where we've been."

We started making a list.

The gym.

The library.

The storage building.

Room 75.

The trophy room.

The principal's office.

The cafeteria.

The stage.

"The stage," Brad said.

"What about it?"

"The old Festival Cup ceremony happened on the stage."

We ran back to the gym.

The stage was still covered in decorations.

We searched underneath it.

Nothing.

Behind it.

Nothing.

Under the seats.

Nothing.

Then Sophie noticed something.

"Wait."

She pointed at the giant school banner hanging above the stage.

There was a black hawk symbol hidden behind it.

We pulled the banner down.

Behind it was a small metal panel.

I touched it.

It opened.

Inside was...

A plastic cup.

Noah stared at it.

"Seriously?"

I picked it up.

It was a normal drinking cup.

On the bottom was written:

NICE TRY.

We had been tricked.

Someone had left it there just to make us think we were close.

Brad clenched his fists.

"They're playing with us."

Then I noticed something.

The plastic cup had a tiny number written underneath.

75.

Room 75 again.

CHAPTER 62

The Wrong Room

We returned to Room 75.

The room looked exactly the same.

Dusty shelves.

Old desk.

Broken computer.

Black Hawks documents.

But this time, Sophie noticed something on the floor.

A small square of newer carpet.

She pulled it back.

There was a trapdoor.

Noah immediately backed away.

"No."

Brad opened it.

There was a ladder.

Of course there was.

I climbed down.

The tunnel was much larger than the one we'd found before.

It stretched underneath the school.

There were pipes running along the walls.

And old wires.

We followed it for several minutes.

Then we reached another door.

This one had no number.

Only a hawk symbol.

Sophie pushed it open.

Inside was a room full of old festival decorations.

But something was different.

Everything looked recently moved.

There were fresh footprints in the dust.

Someone had been here.

We followed them.

They stopped at a wall.

Brad touched it.

Nothing.

Sophie examined the bricks.

Then she smiled.

"This isn't a wall."

She pushed one brick.

CLICK.

The entire section opened.

Behind it was a small room.

And inside was a table.

On the table was the Festival Cup.

We all froze.

"We found it."

I reached for it.

Then the lights turned on.

A voice came from the speaker above us.

"Finally."

The door slammed shut.

CHAPTER 63

The Truth About the Cup

The voice continued.

"You wanted to know what happened five years ago."

I looked around.

"Who are you?"

No answer.

Then a projector turned on.

An old video appeared on the wall.

It showed the festival from five years ago.

The Black Hawks were standing backstage.

Daniel was arguing with someone.

Emily was there too.

Then the Festival Cup was carried into the room.

A teacher walked in.

He was holding a folder.

The video became blurry.

Then we heard shouting.

Daniel grabbed the trophy.

Emily yelled:

"Put it away!"

Daniel replied:

"I'm trying to stop this!"

Then the video ended.

Noah looked confused.

"That's it?"

Sophie shook her head.

"No."

She pointed at the screen.

"Look at the timestamp."

It read:

7:15 PM.

Brad looked at the cup.

"So the trophy wasn't stolen."

"No," I said.

"It was hidden."

"But why?"

The speaker crackled.

The voice returned.

"Because someone was stealing money from the festival."

Everyone went silent.

The voice continued.

"The Black Hawks discovered it."

Daniel had tried to expose the person.

Emily wanted proof.

The trophy was hidden so the thief couldn't use the festival ceremony to cover up what they had done.

Then the recording stopped.

I looked at the speaker.

"Who was stealing the money?"

Silence.

Then the voice said:

"Look at the old accounts."

CHAPTER 64

The Old Accounts

We searched the room.

Behind the Festival Cup was a box of old financial records.

Sophie opened it.

There were pages of festival budgets.

Receipts.

Donations.

Bank records.

We started comparing them.

Most of the numbers were normal.

Then Sophie stopped.

"Look."

She pointed to one page.

There was a donation listed as:

R10 000

But the receipt only showed:

R6 500

Brad frowned.

"Where did the other R3 500 go?"

We found another one.

R5 000 became R3 200.

Another R8 000 became R5 000.

Someone had been taking money.

Noah looked at the records.

"Who signed these?"

Sophie checked.

Her face changed.

"The festival supervisor."

"Who was that?"

She turned the page around.

There was a name.

MR. HARPER.

I recognized him.

He was one of the teachers still working at our school.

Noah's eyes widened.

"He's still here?"

"Yes."

Brad stood up.

"We need to find him."

But before we could leave, the speaker crackled again.

"Don't."

We froze.

The voice continued.

"Mr. Harper isn't the person you're looking for."

Sophie looked confused.

"Then why show us his name?"

The speaker went silent.

I stared at the Festival Cup.

Someone was deliberately giving us clues.

But they were also deliberately sending us in the wrong direction.

CHAPTER 65

Mr. Harper

We found Mr. Harper in the teachers' lounge.

He was drinking coffee.

We showed him the old documents.

His face went pale.

"Where did you get those?"

"Room 75."

He put the cup down.

"You shouldn't have gone there."

Everyone seemed to say that.

I was starting to get tired of it.

"Did you steal the money?"

Mr. Harper looked offended.

"No."

"Then explain the records."

He took the papers.

After looking at them for a few seconds, he sighed.

"I didn't steal anything."

"Then who did?"

"I don't know."

Sophie looked at him.

"You were the festival supervisor."

"Yes."

"And you signed the records."

"Yes."

"Then someone must have changed them."

Mr. Harper nodded.

"That's what I believed."

"Why didn't you report it?"

He looked away.

"Because when I tried, the records disappeared."

That sounded familiar.

Missing pages.

Missing documents.

Missing equipment.

Someone had been making evidence disappear for years.

Then Mr. Harper said something that shocked us.

"Emily tried to warn me."

"What did she say?"

He looked directly at me.

"She said someone inside the school couldn't be trusted."

I remembered the letter.

The person helping you is the one you should fear.

CHAPTER 66

The Festival Competition

We had almost forgotten about the actual festival.

The sports tournament was still happening.

Brad had made it to the final.

He walked onto the court.

I shouted from the sidelines.

"YOU'VE GOT THIS!"

He looked at me.

"Don't distract me!"

I shouted louder.

"YOU'VE DEFINITELY GOT THIS!"

He missed the ball.

"TIM!"

I laughed.

The final was incredibly close.

Brad's team was losing by one point.

Ten seconds remained.

Brad got the ball.

He ran down the court.

Three seconds.

Two.

One.

He threw it.

SWISH.

The crowd exploded.

Brad's team won.

He ran over to me.

"Did you see that?"

"Yep."

"I knew I could do it."

"I knew you could do it too."

He smiled.

Then he handed me the ball.

"Next year."

"What?"

"Next year, we're on the same team."

I smiled.

"Deal."

For once, Brad wasn't trying to beat me.

He was asking me to work with him.

Then Sophie came running toward us.

"We found something."

The smile disappeared from my face.

"What?"

She held up an old photograph.

"This was taken five years ago."

There were seven people in it.

But this time, the seventh person's face wasn't scratched out.

We could see her clearly.

Emily Hart.

And standing beside her...

Was someone we knew.

CHAPTER 67

The Photograph

We stared at the photograph.

Emily was standing beside a younger version of someone from our school.

Someone we had seen almost every day.

I couldn't believe it.

Noah looked at me.

"Who is that?"

I didn't answer.

Brad took the photograph.

"It's..."

He stopped.

Sophie finished the sentence.

"The principal."

Everyone went quiet.

The principal was much younger in the photograph.

He was standing with the Black Hawks.

But he wasn't wearing a Black Hawks jacket.

He was wearing a teacher's uniform.

That explained why he knew so much.

But it raised another question.

"Why was he there?"

We ran to his office.

He wasn't there.

His desk was empty.

His chair was pushed back.

And one drawer was open.

Inside was a black folder.

We opened it.

It contained a list of names.

The same names from the secret room.

But beside each name was a date.

And beside Emily's name was:

RETURN: 2026

Noah looked terrified.

"He knew she was coming back."

Then Brad found another paper.

It said:

THE CUP MUST NEVER BE FOUND.

I stared at it.

"Why would the principal want the cup hidden?"

Before anyone could answer, we heard the office door close behind us.

We turned around.

The principal was standing there.

CHAPTER 68

The Principal's Secret

The principal looked at the folder in my hands.

"You weren't supposed to find that."

Nobody spoke.

Finally I asked:

"Are you the person behind this?"

He shook his head.

"No."

"Then why were you hiding everything?"

He sat down.

"Because five years ago, I made a mistake."

He explained.

When the Black Hawks discovered the missing money, they brought the evidence to him.

He was only a teacher at the time.

He investigated.

But before he could report it, the person responsible threatened the students.

So he hid the Festival Cup.

He hoped the situation would disappear.

It didn't.

Daniel was blamed.

Emily left.

The Black Hawks broke apart.

And the truth stayed hidden.

"But why didn't you tell us?"

"Because I was afraid."

Noah looked shocked.

"You?"

The principal nodded.

"I should have told the truth years ago."

I looked at the folder.

"Then who's been sending us the notes?"

"I don't know."

"Who stole the trophy?"

"I don't know."

"Who is helping us?"

The principal stared at me.

"I don't know."

Then he pointed toward the door.

"But I know one thing."

"What?"

"Emily didn't come back alone."

CHAPTER 69

The Second Person

The principal told us Emily had contacted him weeks ago.

She said she had discovered who stole the festival money.

But she wouldn't tell him the name.

She wanted to expose them publicly.

"Then why is she hiding?" Sophie asked.

"Because she believes someone is still protecting the thief."

Brad looked at the secret files.

"Someone at the school?"

The principal nodded.

Then he said something else.

"Emily wasn't the person sending you those notes."

My stomach dropped.

"What?"

"The handwriting isn't hers."

Sophie immediately pulled out all the notes.

She compared them.

The handwriting was different.

Someone else had been sending the messages.

Someone who knew what Emily was doing.

Someone who knew about the old Black Hawks.

Someone who knew where the Festival Cup was.

Someone who had access to the school.

And someone who had been helping us.

I suddenly remembered something.

"Wait."

Everyone looked at me.

"The person helping us."

Sophie nodded.

"They've been giving us clues."

Brad frowned.

"Why help us if they're the bad guy?"

I looked at the notes.

"Maybe they're not helping us."

Noah's face went pale.

"Then what are they doing?"

I whispered:

"They're controlling where we look."

CHAPTER 70

The Last Clue

We returned to the hidden room.

The Festival Cup was still sitting on the table.

But now there was something underneath it.

A small envelope.

I opened it.

Inside was one final photograph.

It showed the original Black Hawks standing outside the school.

On the back was written:

THE TRUTH ENDS WHERE IT BEGAN.

Sophie looked at the photograph.

"The old festival."

Brad shook his head.

"Room 75?"

"No," I said.

"The principal's office?"

"No."

I looked at the photograph.

There was something in the background.

A clock.

It showed 7:15.

And beneath the clock was a sign.

MAIN HALL.

We ran to the main hall.

There was an old clock hanging above the entrance.

Nobody had paid attention to it for years.

I climbed onto a chair.

Then a table.

Then another chair.

Sophie shouted:

"Tim, get down!"

"I'm fine!"

I reached behind the clock.

My hand touched something.

A small metal box.

I pulled it out.

Inside was a USB drive.

And a note.

PLAY THIS AT THE FINAL FESTIVAL CEREMONY.

Brad stared at it.

"Tomorrow?"

I nodded.

The festival's final ceremony was tomorrow evening.

Whatever was on that drive could reveal everything.

Then my phone buzzed.

Unknown number.

A message appeared:

DON'T PLAY THE VIDEO.

A second message appeared.

OR SOMEONE WILL GET HURT.

I looked at my friends.

For once, nobody made a joke.

Because tomorrow wasn't just the final day of the festival.

It was the day we were finally going to find out who had been behind everything.

CHAPTER 71

The Final Day

The final day of the festival had arrived.

I barely slept.

Mostly because every time I closed my eyes, I imagined someone sneaking into my room and stealing the USB drive.

By 8:00 AM, I was already at school.

Sophie was there.

Brad was there.

Noah was there.

Even Greg was there.

I held up the USB drive.

"This is it."

Sophie nodded.

"If the video shows what we think it does, we'll finally know the truth."

Brad looked around.

"Where's the principal?"

Nobody knew.

That was worrying.

We searched his office.

Empty.

His desk was covered in papers.

Then we found a note.

I'M SORRY.

That's it.

No explanation.

No name.

No clue.

Noah looked at me.

"That's not suspicious at all."

We went to the main hall.

The final ceremony was scheduled for 7:15 PM.

Exactly the same time the Festival Cup disappeared five years ago.

All day, the festival continued.

Games.

Food.

Music.

Sports.

Everyone was having fun.

But we were waiting.

At 6:50 PM, Sophie checked the USB drive.

"Ready?"

I nodded.

Brad stood beside us.

Noah was holding Greg.

"Why are you holding the chicken?"

"I don't know."

"You've been holding him for three hours."

"I've become emotionally attached."

At 7:00, we walked onto the stage.

The crowd began cheering.

The principal was still missing.

Then the lights suddenly went out.

The entire hall went silent.

A projector turned on.

The USB drive had started playing.

By itself.

CHAPTER 72

The Video

The screen showed the school five years ago.

The old festival.

The Black Hawks.

Daniel.

Emily.

And the principal.

Everyone watched silently.

Then the video showed the Festival Cup ceremony.

A teacher carried the trophy backstage.

The camera followed.

We saw someone enter the room.

It was Mr. Harper.

Noah whispered:

"Oh."

Mr. Harper wasn't alone.

Another person entered.

The video became blurry.

But we could hear them talking.

"You can't keep taking the money."

Mr. Harper sounded angry.

"I didn't take anything."

The other person laughed.

Then they opened a box.

Inside were envelopes filled with cash.

Festival money.

The video suddenly changed.

We saw Emily.

She was filming everything.

She had discovered the truth.

Then Daniel entered.

He saw the camera.

"Emily, we have to get out of here."

But they didn't get out.

The other person noticed them.

They chased after them.

The video became shaky.

Emily grabbed the Festival Cup.

She ran into Room 75.

Daniel followed.

They hid the trophy.

Then the video showed someone else entering the room.

Someone wearing a school uniform.

They found the hidden camera.

They looked directly into it.

The video froze.

The face was finally visible.

Everyone in the hall gasped.

I knew that face.

We all did.

It was...

CHAPTER 73

The Real Black Hawk

The video paused.

The face on the screen was the face of someone who had been at the school for years.

But it wasn't the principal.

It wasn't Daniel.

It wasn't Mr. Harper.

It wasn't Emily.

It was a former student.

Someone who had returned to the school during the festival preparations.

Someone who had been watching us.

Someone who knew exactly where everything was.

And then the projector shut off.

The hall went completely dark.

A voice came from the back.

"You shouldn't have played that."

Everyone turned.

A figure stepped forward.

Emily Hart.

She walked onto the stage.

Behind her was Daniel Cross.

And behind Daniel was the principal.

The crowd started whispering.

Emily looked at me.

"You found the truth."

I held up the USB.

"But who was the person in the video?"

Emily looked toward the back of the hall.

Everyone turned.

A person slowly walked forward.

It was Mr. Harper.

He looked nervous.

Then he smiled.

"You really had to ruin everything, didn't you?"

The hall erupted.

Teachers moved toward him.

But Mr. Harper didn't run.

Instead, he looked at Emily.

"You don't understand."

Emily shook her head.

"I understand perfectly."

Five years ago, Mr. Harper had been stealing money from the festival.

The Black Hawks discovered him.

Emily recorded the evidence.

Daniel tried to help her.

The principal found out.

But Mr. Harper threatened to make sure the evidence disappeared.

The principal hid the Festival Cup.

Daniel was blamed.

Emily left the school.

The Black Hawks broke apart.

But Mr. Harper stayed.

Then, years later, he discovered Emily had returned.

So he started sending the messages.

He stole the equipment.

He moved the trophy.

He created the mystery.

He wanted us to blame Daniel again.

But he made one mistake.

He underestimated us.

Mr. Harper looked at me.

"You kids weren't supposed to find Room 75."

I smiled.

"Yeah."

I held up Greg.

"But we had a chicken."

Noah raised Greg's wing.

"Best detective ever."

CHAPTER 74

The Festival Cup

Mr. Harper was taken away by the authorities.

The school was finally told the truth.

The missing money was discovered in old records.

The Festival Cup was returned.

Daniel's name was cleared.

Emily finally explained everything.

The Black Hawks hadn't been villains.

They had been students who discovered something wrong and tried to stop it.

They made mistakes.

But they weren't responsible for stealing the trophy.

The principal apologized to Daniel.

Daniel accepted.

Then he looked at us.

"You did what we couldn't."

Brad smiled.

"Team effort."

Sophie nodded.

Noah raised his hand.

"I mostly ate popcorn."

"That's true," I said.

The principal walked onto the stage holding the Festival Cup.

"The festival almost didn't happen."

Everyone became quiet.

"But because of these students, it did."

He looked at me.

"Tim, Sophie, Noah, Brad, Mia, Ethan, Kyle..."

The crowd cheered.

Then the principal announced something I wasn't expecting.

"This year's Student Contribution Award goes to..."

He paused.

I looked at Brad.

Brad looked at me.

The principal smiled.

"Tim."

Everyone cheered.

I walked onto the stage.

The principal handed me the trophy.

I held it up.

Then I realized something.

It wasn't actually mine.

It belonged to the school.

So I placed it back on the table.

Then I grabbed the microphone.

"Can I say something?"

The principal nodded.

I looked at everyone.

"Five years ago, some students tried to protect this school."

I looked at Daniel and Emily.

"Today, we finished what they started."

Everyone cheered.

Then Noah shouted:

"AND WE FOUND IT WITH A RUBBER CHICKEN!"

The entire hall laughed.

I held up Greg.

Greg had officially become a legend.

CHAPTER 75

Tim Rules

A few weeks later, everything was back to normal.

The Festival Cup was safely locked away.

The school had new security.

The festival money was being checked properly.

The old Black Hawks mystery was finally solved.

Daniel visited the school sometimes.

Emily helped organize student events.

Mr. Harper was gone.

And the principal had finally stopped looking terrified every time someone mentioned Room 75.

As for me?

I was still student council leader.

One afternoon, Sophie walked into the student council room.

"Tim."

"Yeah?"

"We need a new set of rules."

"Rules?"

"Yes."

She put a piece of paper on the desk.

At the top it said:

STUDENT COUNCIL RULES

Rule 1:

Don't enter secret rooms without permission.

Rule 2:

Don't investigate suspicious people alone.

Rule 3:

Don't touch mysterious USB drives.

Rule 4:

Don't use festival equipment as weapons.

Rule 5:

Don't keep food in your locker for more than one day.

I looked at Rule 5.

"That one's specifically about me."

"Yes."

Noah walked in.

"What's Rule 6?"

Sophie wrote:

Rule 6: Noah is not allowed to eat the evidence.

Noah looked offended.

"I only ate one clue."

"YOU ATE A CLUE?"

"It looked like a cookie!"

Brad walked in carrying Frank.

"Chicken battle?"

I held up Greg.

"Always."

Sophie sighed.

"You people are impossible."

I looked around the room.

Noah.

Sophie.

Brad.

Greg.

Frank.

Everyone who had somehow become part of the strangest year of my life.

I thought about everything that had happened.

The election.

The talent show.

The fundraisers.

The festival.

The Black Hawks.

Room 75.

The Festival Cup.

And the mystery.

It had all started because my name accidentally ended up on a student council election list.

And somehow...

I became the leader.

I opened my notebook and wrote one final sentence.

Being student council leader is probably the worst job in the world.

I stopped.

Then I crossed it out.

Underneath, I wrote:

Actually...

It's pretty awesome.

Noah looked over my shoulder.

"What are you writing?"

I closed the notebook.

"Nothing."

He grabbed it.

I chased him around the room.

Sophie yelled at us.

Brad started a chicken battle.

Greg fell off the table.

Frank landed on the floor.

And I realized something.

Maybe being the leader wasn't about making the perfect decisions.

Maybe it wasn't about being the smartest person.

Maybe it wasn't about winning every competition.

It was about having people around you who would follow you into a secret underground room...

Even when they knew it was probably a terrible idea.

I looked at my friends.

Then I smiled.

I had one final rule.

RULE #1:

TIM RULES.

And honestly...

I think that's all that matters.

THE END.